

Gymkhana Club committee urges Centre to halt disruption till clarity



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The general committee overseeing Delhi Gymkhana Club on Monday urged the Centre not to disrupt the functioning of the institution until clarity emerges on issues including relocation of the club and protection of employees, according to a letter sent to the Land and Development Office (L&DO). In the letter, the committee constituted by the Government of India requested the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs and the L&DO to consider allotting an alternative plot of land for relocation of the club in case the takeover proceeds. One of the committee members said the interests of members, employees and other stakeholders should be protected before any decision affecting the club's operations is implemented. The general committee said it had been working for over four years to improve the club's administration and financial condition after taking charge under the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) order of April 1, 2022. It said the club had witnessed a financial turnaround under its tenure,

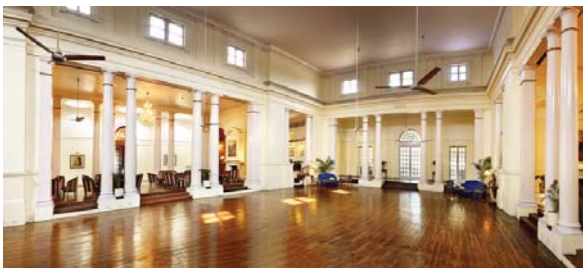
with the projected profit and loss statement for 2023-24 showing a profit of ₹9.25 crore against a loss of ₹12.39 crore in 2021-22. It said the turnaround was achieved without adding new memberships, which had earlier been a major source of revenue for the club. It had streamlined administrative processes, introduced standard operating procedures across departments and reduced pending litigation, including labour disputes, the committee further said. It also claimed that efforts had been made to digitise and update membership records, noting that nearly 43 per cent of such records were unavailable in 2022. According to the letter, the committee members appointed by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) were professionals working in an honorary capacity without any sitting fee, financial benefit or reimbursement of expenses. The committee also said relocation of the club would require substantial expenditure for rebuilding infrastructure and facilities developed over several decades. Meanwhile, members of the club held a meeting on Monday and termed the pro-

posed takeover "illegal", while also raising concerns over what they described as selective action against the institution. The members said "similar clubs should get similar treatment" and argued that the perception of the club as an illegitimate user of public land was "misleading", stating that the premises are actively used for sports, recreation and cultural activities by thousands of members and their families. A member of the general committee said discussions were underway with officials of the L&DO and the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs to prevent the takeover. "We are in regular conversation with the L&DO and officials in the Urban Development Ministry. We are trying our best to ensure that the club continues at its present location," he said. The committee is also seeking protection for around 600 employees associated with the club in the event of relocation, the member added. Members also said long waiting lists for membership reflected demand rather than illegitimacy and called for reforms in governance instead of the closure of the institution.

Over 9 months, L&DO warned Club thrice on dues, lease terms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Land and Development Office (L&DO) had sent three letters to the Delhi Gymkhana Club (DGC) over a period of nine months regarding unpaid or revised ground rent and lease violations. These notices set the stage for the high-profile eviction/re-entry order issued on May 22, 2026. This order required the club to vacate its 27.3-acre premises at 2, Safdarjung Road by June 5, 2026, citing public purpose, defence infrastructure, and national security needs under Clause 4 of the perpetual lease deed. In the first letter written to the Delhi Gymkhana Club on September 12, 2025, the L&DO



raised the demand for revised ground rent with interest to the tune of ₹32.88 crore. This was followed up with a second letter on 27 March, where it asked the club to furnish copies of all rent deeds executed with the Punjab National Bank for "determination and finalization of charges." Failing to get a response, the L&DO wrote a third letter on 16 May, where it said, "The

office space leased to the Punjab National Bank are yet to be calculated due to non-submission of the information requested on March 27, 2026. These charges will be communicated separately upon receipt and examination of the requisite documents," it said. The L&DO added that failure to comply with these directions and remit the outstanding amount of Rs 47.58 crore within the stipulated 7-day period "will constrain this office to initiate re-entry proceedings for the premises, in accordance with the terms and conditions of the lease deed." The rent dispute comes amid wider allegations of financial misconduct and administrative irregularities flagged by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) during its 2022 inspection of the club. Notably, the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) had pointed out several unlawful practices at the Delhi Gymkhana Club after its inspection in 2022. An audit and inspection of the Delhi Gymkhana Club by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) in 2022 revealed grave irregularities and violations of the Companies Act. Following the investigation, the MCA successfully petitioned the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), resulting in the suspension of the club's General Committee and the appointment of Government-nominated directors to run its affairs.

Club management assures job security, denies immediate shutdown

MANSI JAGANI ■ New Delhi

The Delhi Gymkhana Club management assured concerned employees on Monday that their jobs were secure and that the club would not close immediately, days after the Centre directed the iconic institution to vacate its premises in Lutyens' Delhi by June 5. This reassurance came amid growing anxiety among nearly 600 employees, many of whom reported they had received no formal updates regarding the club's future, salaries, or potential relocation plans since the Government's order was issued last week. On Monday morning, a group of employees gathered at a small shrine, belonging to 'Pir Baba', located opposite the club's exit gate, praying for a

favourable outcome as fears over livelihoods and job security deepened inside the century-old institution. Soon after the visit to the shrine, the staff said they were informed by members of the general committee that legal and administrative efforts were underway to protect staff interests. "We received a call from club president Malay Sinha and director Kuldeep Chahal during the day. They assured us that our concerns had been conveyed to the Government through a special written note and that discussions were underway. They said that the highest priority was being given to staff welfare to ensure that no employee suffered any adverse consequences," Nandan Singh Negi, president of the Gymkhana Employee



Welfare Association, said. Negi added that the club management also assured employees that the club would not shut down on June 5 and that their jobs were secure. Inside the sprawling Safdarjung Road premises, employees described an atmosphere heavy with panic and constant speculation, with many saying they first learnt about the devel-

opment through news reports and frantic conversations among members rather than through official channels. "We were not formally informed about the closure. That day, suddenly, all the members' phones started ringing. By night, more members began arriving at the club to discuss the order. We only learned about it through phone calls, news reports, and conversations with others. Since that day, many of us have not slept well. We have families to care for and households to run," a club employee said. The Land and Development Office under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry had directed the club to hand over its 27.3-acre premises by June 5, stating that the land was required for "urgent institutional needs, governance infrastructure and public interest project," including strengthening defence-related infrastructure. Despite the reassurances, several employees noted that no written communication guaranteeing job security had been issued yet. They are also considering legal action if clarity regarding compensation and rehabilitation is not provided soon. (PTI)

Capital logs hottest May night in 14 years at 32.4°C: IMD

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi recorded its hottest night for the month of May in nearly 14 years on Monday as the minimum temperature settled at 32.4 degrees Celsius, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). The temperature was 5.7 degrees above the seasonal average, indicating severe heat stress conditions across the capital. IMD data showed that the last time Delhi witnessed a higher minimum temperature in May was on May 26, 2012, when the mercury stood

at 32.5 degrees Celsius. Earlier this month, the city had also experienced unusually warm nights, with the minimum temperature touching 31.9 degrees Celsius on May 21. According to the IMD, several weather stations across Delhi recorded temperatures significantly above normal levels. Palam recorded a minimum temperature of 30.5 degrees Celsius, which was 3.4 degrees above normal. Lodhi Road registered 30 degrees Celsius, five degrees above normal, while Ridge recorded 30.6 degrees Celsius, 4.4 degrees above normal. Ayanagar saw one of the



highest readings at 32 degrees Celsius, which was 5.3 degrees above the seasonal average. An IMD official said warm night conditions were observed at Safdarjung, Lodhi Road, and Ayanagar. The department defines a warm night as a situation where the maximum daytime temperature reaches at least 40 degrees Celsius, and the minimum temperature remains between 4.5 degrees and 6.4 degrees above normal. The soaring night tempera-

tures have brought little relief to residents already struggling with intense daytime heat. Meteorologists said such conditions are considered particularly dangerous because the human body gets less time to recover from extreme daytime temperatures. The weather department has issued a yellow alert for heatwave conditions in Delhi. The maximum temperature on Monday was expected to hover around 44 degrees Celsius. Officials warned people to avoid prolonged exposure to direct sunlight during afternoon hours and advised residents to remain hydrated.

Delhi CM, Speaker ride metro, bus to push public transport use

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta and other ministers travelled by Metro and bus on Monday as part of the 'Metro Monday' initiative aimed at saving fuel and promoting public transport use. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday travelled to the Delhi Secretariat by Metro and DTC bus as part of the Government's 'Metro Monday' campaign. She urged residents to use public transport regularly to help reduce pollution, traffic congestion, and fuel consumption in the capital.



This was the second consecutive Monday that the Chief Minister used public transport under the initiative launched by the Delhi

Secretariat, the Chief Minister interacted with Metro and bus passengers and appealed to people to actively participate in the campaign. The Chief Minister said wider use of buses and Metro services would help improve traffic conditions in Delhi while also supporting environmental protection and fuel conservation efforts. According to her, the campaign is linked to the Delhi Government's 'Mera Bharat, Mera Yogdan' initiative, launched in response to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal for greater public participation in fuel-saving measures.

The Chief Minister said the idea behind the campaign is to encourage people to dedicate at least one day every week to public transport use. She said increasing dependence on shared mobility and public transport systems could significantly reduce the number of vehicles on Delhi roads. "Every Metro ride and every bus journey contributes to fuel savings and lower pollution," the Chief Minister said during the interaction with commuters. She added that reducing the use of private vehicles would also help improve travel times and ease traffic congestion in the city.

Govt slashes officials' domestic travel spend by 25% in new order

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Days after restricting all official foreign travel for its personnel, including officers and staff members, until further notice, the Delhi Government has issued a fresh directive to reduce the domestic travel expenses of its officials by 25 per cent. The move is a part of the Government's "austerity" measures in response to uncertain global fuel supplies affecting the country's economy. A communication by the Finance Department to various Government departments stated that, considering the current economic climate and the necessity for prudent financial management, both the Government of India and the Delhi Government have implemented several "austerity and expenditure rationalisation measures." These measures are designed to curb unnecessary expenses and address fiscal imbalances caused, among other factors, by rising global oil prices and other economic pressures, it said. As part of this initiative, domestic travel expenses must be regulated so that each department stays within its allocated budget, reflecting the mandatory 25 per cent reduction com-

pared to the previous financial year, the order said. Moreover, to promote fiscal discipline and ensure optimal use of public resources, officers are required to exercise caution when selecting air travel classes to remain within budgetary constraints. The communication also emphasised that video conferencing should be effectively utilised for attending meetings and conferences, particularly when travel from distant locations is necessary. However, in cases of official emergencies, the restrictions may be relaxed with the approval of the chief minister or the finance minister. The restriction will apply to all departments, autonomous bodies, local bodies, academies, boards, corporations, societies, and grantee institutions under the administrative control of the Delhi Government. The administrative secretaries or heads of the departments have been directed by the finance department to ensure strict compliance with the instructions. The Delhi Government had on May 14 launched a large-scale public participation campaign titled 'Mera Bharat, Mera Yogdan'. The 90-day campaign aims to involve both Government institutions and ordinary citizens in building a more self-reliant and resource-conscious India. As part of the initiative, the Government has announced a series of measures focused on fuel conservation, promotion of public transport, support for Made-in-India products and responsible lifestyle practices.



Traffic Police uses solar-powered cooling helmets to protect officers during heatwave

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As blistering temperatures in the national Capital and its neighbouring regions surged past 45 degrees Celsius, the Delhi Traffic Police has rolled out an innovative pilot project that could redefine how front-line personnel survive India's unforgiving summers. For the first time, traffic officers at some of the city's busiest intersections are using wearable cooling devices, such as solar-powered air-conditioned helmets, portable fans, and improved hydration kits. The project, which began quietly over the weekend,

focuses on officers working at high-exposure spots such as the Teen Murti roundabout and other major junctions, where the heat from concrete, vehicles, and sunlight is intense. Senior police officials say this move is not just for comfort; it is an important step to prevent heatstroke, dehydration, and exhaustion among officers who spend eight to ten hours a day in heavy uniforms and gear that trap heat. The main feature of the project is a specially designed cooling helmet. It has a battery-powered temperature-control system and solar panels that can lower the

temperature around the wearer's head by 8 to 12 degrees Celsius compared to the outside air. Police logistics teams note that the head is one of the body's most heat-sensitive areas, and cooling it quickly helps maintain core body temperature and alertness, which is important for officers managing traffic in tough conditions. Along with the helmets, officers are also using simple yet effective tools such as battery-powered handheld fans, neck fans, and small table fans that can be set up at traffic booths. Temporary tin shelters have been put up at key locations to give officers short breaks from the



sun and protection during sudden dust storms that often happen before the monsoon. Medical support has also been improved. Chilled water and Oral Rehydration Salts (ORS) are now readily available at certain points, and supervisors are monitoring for early signs of heat-related illness. "Our men and women are the silent guardians of the city's roads," a senior officer involved in the project told PTI on condition of anonymity. "When the mercury crosses 45°C, every minute under the sun becomes a battle. These devices are small but powerful tools in that battle." The pilot is currently limited to a few high-traffic areas and will run for a few weeks. Its success, based on officer feedback, health records, and productivity, will determine whether the technology is used across the entire Delhi Traffic Police force. So far, officers have responded very positively, saying they feel less tired and can focus better during afternoon shifts. Delhi and the National Capital Region have been under a severe heatwave alert for several days. The India Meteorological Department has warned that temperatures will stay 4-6 degrees above normal, with no relief expected until the monsoon.

IN FOCUS



Goats are displayed for sale at a livestock market ahead of Bakra Eid (Eid al-Adha) in Surat, Gujarat

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Scorching heat pushed temperatures across several states on Monday, with Uttar Pradesh's Banda district and Maharashtra's Brahmapuri region emerging as the hottest places in the country at 47.6 degrees Celsius each, the Indian Meteorological Department (IMD) said.

According to the IMD, a heatwave is declared in the plains if the maximum temperature exceeds 45 degrees, while temperatures above 47 degrees are categorised as a severe heatwave.

At least 6 places in Uttar Pradesh featured in the IMD's list of locations recording maximum temperatures of over 45 degrees Celsius. Banda recorded the highest temperature at 47.6 degrees, around 4.1 notches above normal.

Jhansi's maximum temperature was at 46 degrees Celsius, followed by Orai at 45.8 degrees, Agra at 45.5 degrees, Prayagraj at



Women covering themselves to shield from the scorching heat in Rishikesh

45.4 degrees and Hamirpur at 45.2 degrees Celsius.

According to the IMD, heatwave to severe heatwave conditions are likely at isolated places in eastern Uttar Pradesh on Tuesday, while western parts of the state are also expected to witness heatwave conditions during daytime. Warm

nights have also been forecast in both regions.

The Uttar Pradesh Government has already issued advisories asking people to avoid stepping outdoors between noon and 4 pm unless necessary, wear light and breathable clothes, and maintain hydration through seasonal fruits

Severe heatwave pushes mercury in India to 47.6°C

and fluids. For Maharashtra, the IMD has sent a heatwave alert for the Vidarbha region for two days, while an orange alert has been issued thereafter till May 28.

Brahmapuri again emerged as the hottest place in the country, recording 47.6 degrees Celsius, 5 notches above normal. Several other places in the region also recorded maximum temperatures above 46 degrees Celsius.

Nagpur registered 46.5 degrees Celsius, followed by Gadchiroli and Bhandara at 46.4 degrees each, Gondia at 46.1 degrees, Wardha, Jhansi at 46 degrees and Akola at 45.4 degrees.

In Rajasthan, severe heatwave conditions continued to grip large parts of the state, with Kota at 45.6 degrees Celsius remaining the hottest place in the state, according to the met department.

Temperatures in other cities also hovered around the 45-degree mark. Chittorgarh and Sriganaganagar recorded maximum temperatures of 45 degrees Celsius

each, while Pilani registered 44.5 degrees Celsius.

The mercury settled at 44.4 degrees Celsius in Alwar, 44.3 degrees Celsius in Jaisalmer and 44.2 degrees Celsius in Bikaner.

In Haryana, Sirsa recorded the highest temperature in the state at 46.2 degrees Celsius, followed by Rohtak at 45.2 degrees.

In Madhya Pradesh, Khajuraho emerged as the hottest place in the state at 47.2 degrees Celsius.

The national capital, Delhi, also saw its mercury hovering around 44 degrees, with Ridge station registering maximum temperature at 44.3 degrees Celsius.

"Heat wave to severe heat wave conditions are likely to continue over central and northwest India during the next 4-5 days, and in the east & adjoining peninsular India during the next 3-4 days," the IMD said. "Reduction in maximum temperatures and abatement of heatwave conditions are likely from 29th May," it added.

No Ebola case reported in India so far, says JP Nadda

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

No case of Ebola Virus has been reported in India so far, said Union Health Minister J P Nadda on Monday, directing officials to ensure all surveillance and testing arrangements remain in a state of readiness.

"India has not reported any case of Bundibugyo Ebola disease to date," Nadda said. According to an official statement, during a high-level meeting with senior officials of the Union Health Ministry, Nadda assessed the country's readiness amid global concern over Ebola and directed that all preventive mechanisms remain fully alert and operational. Nadda said, "Enhanced screening and surveillance measures



have been initiated at international airports and other points of entry, and advisories along with Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) on screening, quarantine, clinical management, labora-

tory testing and infection prevention practices have been shared with all States and Union Territories."

Meanwhile, aviation watchdog DGCA has asked airlines to implement various

measures, including making in-flight announcements and mandatory filing of self-declaration forms from passengers originating or transiting through the affected countries. Meetings have also been

held with States/Union Territories and stakeholders concerned to review preparedness and response measures.

On the minister's directions, the Union Health Secretary chaired a joint review meeting with officials from various ministries and agencies concerned to strengthen coordination and preparedness measures, the statement said.

Nadda instructed authorities to keep Ebola screening arrangements at all points of entry across the country, including airports, seaports and land border crossings, fully vigilant and robust, it said. He also directed the Secretary, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and the

National Centre for Disease Control (NCDC) to ensure that all necessary arrangements for tracking, testing and surveillance remain in a constant state of readiness.

The Centre has intensified precautionary measures after the World Health Organization declared the Ebola outbreak a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC). The Africa Centres for Disease Control and Prevention has also designated it a Public Health Emergency of Continental Security (PHECS).

Officials said surveillance at ports of entry and coordination among agencies are being closely monitored to ensure early detection and prompt response to any suspected case.

ED summons AAP MLA in DA-linked PMLA case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jalandhar

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has summoned AAP Punjab MLA Raman Arora for questioning in a money laundering case linked to alleged possession of disproportionate assets next week here, officials said on Monday.

Arora is a legislator from the Jalandhar Central assembly seat. Officials said he has been asked to depose before the central agency on June 2 at the ED office in Jalandhar following which his statement will be recorded under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

The MLA was earlier arrested and charge-sheeted



by the Punjab Vigilance Bureau in a case of alleged possession of disproportionate assets worth ₹1.10 crore, according to the officials. There are allegations against him of extortion from shops and other establishments, they claimed.

Oil shock: Petrol crosses ₹102

As India imports nearly 85-90 per cent of its crude oil requirements, it has been among the worst affected by the surge in crude oil prices. State-owned Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) together control 90 per cent of India's fuel market.

According to Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, the four rounds of petrol and diesel price hike, totalling about ₹7.5 per litre, have trimmed the losses for State-run OMCs to close to ₹600 crore per day. The losses on sale of petrol, diesel and domestic cooking gas LPG were about ₹1,000 crore per day before the start of the May 15 cycle of price revision.

The May 15 increase came after the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) expanded its electoral footprint by winning three of five state and UT elections, including West Bengal.

FM calls for focus on fuel, fertiliser, forex

She admitted that the rising crude oil and fertiliser prices due to the US-Iran war have become a major concern for the country's economy.

"We should appreciate that the challenges are more externally driven. We must also recognise that India's domestic economic situation remains positive and resilient even today," the finance minister said.

She acknowledged that it is a challenge for the small business units to plan for the future, and also added that the crisis, which has been running for over 80 days now is also a challenge for countries, including India. The government's approach is focused on protecting citizens, supporting micro, small and medium enterprises, safeguard exporters and keeping supply chains moving and maintaining economic stability, she said.

Naysayers have created a "cynical and pessimistic narrative" after the Prime Minister's appeal for austerity, she said, stressing that such observations are factually incorrect. "It (the narrative) is wrong because it is fear-mongering. India cannot afford fear-mongering. We need to give confidence to the people with our words and with our actions," she said.

Fuel prices are high, gold prices have climbed to elevated levels, creating concerns on the external front, and there is an "unimaginable increase" in the fertiliser prices, she said, contextualising the call made by the Prime Minister. Therefore, there is a need to look at conserving the forex, she said.

Stating that India's policy response has been calibrated to preserve domestic growth, Sitharaman said the cut in diesel and petrol excise duties will lead to a revenue impact of ₹1 lakh crore.

"All the good that is being done by the common people themselves is forgotten. And a pessimistic, cynical narrative is generated, which is just not right," she said.

She also highlighted that the issue of ₹8.1 lakh crore locked in delayed payments for MSMEs is impacting their working capital and growth, and urged public sector undertakings not to exceed the 45-day window to make payments to them.

Meanwhile, Sitharaman also asked lenders to relook at the design of loans to tailor-make products, where repayments happen when an entity gets its revenues. "My message to Sidbi and every banker here is that standard products cannot serve non-standard businesses," she said, citing examples of how the income generations of businesses vary across multiple activities.

At present, loans are typically given on a monthly repayment basis, which may be weekly as well in the case of microfinance.

"A farmer-linked enterprise does not earn every month. A resort does not earn evenly through the year. A garment exporter waits for payment after shipment. A small auto-comp supplier waits for invoice clearance. A woman entrepreneur may have regular transactions yet no property in her name," Sitharaman said.

"Why should all of them be given the same repayment structure?" the finance minister questioned, asking Sidbi to take the lead to ensure that credit is designed around the business cycle of an enterprise.

No lesson learnt: SC pulls up NTA in NEET paper...

The court directed that a copy of the petitions be served to Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, besides other parties, and asked the NTA, which is responsible for conducting the NEET exam, to file an affidavit by Thursday on compliance of directions issued by the court in 2024.

The SC directed the Centre-appointed committee led by former Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) chief K Radhakrishnan for the overhaul of the functioning of the NTA to detail the steps taken in compliance with its directions.

In 2024, after the question paper leak of the NEET-UG examination, the top court had refused to cancel the exam but passed various directions aimed at tackling paper leaks and also a criterion for cancelling public exams.

The SC had expanded the mandate of the Radhakrishnan committee and directed it to recommend reforms on examination security, transportation of papers, CCTV surveillance, candidate verification, encryption protocols, technological safeguards, real-time monitoring, grievance redressal and adoption of international best practices.

Amit Shah begins border security tour

Next month, the tour will move to India's eastern borders. On June 5, Shah will visit border areas in Tripura to review security along the India-Bangladesh border.

Around June 15, the Home Minister will tour the border regions of West Bengal, another key state that shares a long border with Bangladesh. This visit is important after the recent formation of a BJP-led Government in the State.

Shah has said that BJP Governments in Assam, Tripura, and now West Bengal have implemented strong policies to secure these borders and prevent demographic changes driven by illegal migration.

A high-level meeting with the chief ministers of these states is also planned to strengthen security architecture across several states. Official sources say the tour aims to assess preparedness, interact with frontline personnel, and ensure

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seamless coordination among the BSF, state police, intelligence agencies, and district administrations.

The timing of the tour reflects growing attention to threats from the west, like drone smuggling and hybrid tactics from Pakistan, as well as concerns in the east, such as infiltration and smuggling along the Bangladesh border.

Siddaramaiah, DK Delhi meet fuels buzz

Siddaramaiah has repeatedly asserted that he will complete full five years. Shivakumar, on his part, has consistently maintained that he will abide by the Congress leadership's decision, and time will reveal the outcome regarding the CM change.

Siddaramaiah on Monday said the Congress high command invited him to Delhi for a meeting. He, however, said he was unaware of the meeting's agenda. "I'm invited to Delhi. Tomorrow there is a meeting by 11 am. I don't know the subject. But, I'm invited. Last night, KC Venugopal called me and intimated to me about the date and the meeting," he said. Some Ministers considered close to the CM, like Satish Jarkiholi, G Parameshwara, HC Mahadevappa are also headed to Delhi.

Meanwhile, responding to reporters' queries on his Delhi visit, Shivakumar, who is also the state Congress chief, said, "I'm going." As per the Deputy CM's tour plan shared with the media, Shivakumar left for the national Capital to meet Union Ministers on Tuesday. Not wanting to respond to a question about the CM change issue, Shivakumar said, "I don't know about it, I don't want to comment on it, it's not my job."

However speaking to reporters, AICC General Secretary Incharge Karnataka Randeep Singh Surjewala said, "Rajya Sabha elections have been notified, Council (Legislative Council) elections will happen after that. The party continues to have consultations. So please do not speculate. I quash all other speculations."

Several party leaders are worried that the leadership issue is impacting governance and the image of the Congress government. They have openly demanded that the high command resolve the issue, keeping the party's prospects in the 2028 Assembly polls in mind.

Several AHINDA (Kannada acronym for minorities, backward classes, and Dalits) leaders in the party, seen as part of Siddaramaiah's camp, want one of their own to occupy the coveted post if the leadership changes. Also, there is a demand for a "Dalit CM," with AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge's name being floated by a section of the party, along with Home Minister G Parameshara.

Demand has also grown from a large section of Congress MLAs, who are ministerial aspirants to effect a Cabinet reshuffle, and give some of them an opportunity to serve as ministers by replacing a few existing ones."

Gymkhana Club moves HC

"The Impugned Notice proceeds on vague and generalized assertions relating to "defence infrastructure", "public security purposes" and "governance infrastructure". The Impugned Notice neither identifies any specific public project nor discloses any material, assessment,

approval or necessity justifying repossession of the entirety of the Suit Property. The invocation of Clause 4 is entirely mechanical, unsupported by particulars and reflective of complete non-application of mind," Khurana said in his suit.

"The impugned notice does not provide for any compensation in respect of the loss of the property, the premium paid, or the buildings and structures standing on the premises; is in flagrant violation of Article 300A of the Constitution of India, since Defendant No. 1's own conduct over decades, most pertinently its letter dated 18.12.2009 bearing No. L&DO/L-11B(7)/368 wherein Defendant No. 1 expressly recorded that "your ownership and titles stand restored" to Defendant No. 2, has unambiguously confirmed that the Perpetual Lease Deed confers proprietary rights on Defendant No. 2, which rights cannot be extinguished in an arbitrary manner without an acquisition process with all the attendant safeguards and payment of compensation," Khurana said.

He further stated that the notice is a malicious and colourable exercise, being the last in a series of acts by the government to gain control over the institution, including a recent attempt to take over the management of the institution and amounts to an attempt to effect forced eviction through executive force, administrative fiat and threat/exercise of police power instead of following the due process of law.

Another lawsuit by the Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd Staff Welfare Association against the Centre's order is also scheduled to be taken up by Justice Avneesh Jhingan on Tuesday. It says that the cooks, waiters, kitchen and housekeeping staff, gardeners and groundsman, electricians and plumbers, lifeguards, security personnel, etc., employed at the club seeks protection of their source of livelihood as well as fundamental rights under Articles 14, 19(1)(g) and 21 of the Constitution.

According to the suit, the Impugned Notice further manufactures an artificial urgency by directing surrender of possession within 15 days without disclosing any emergent circumstance warranting such extraordinary action. No breach, misuse or violation of the Perpetual Lease Deed has been alleged against Defendant No. 2 in the Impugned Notice. The impugned action is therefore arbitrary, disproportionate, non-speaking, contrary to the Perpetual Lease Deed and violative of settled principles governing lawful recovery of possession. No lease can be determined unilaterally without using the remedies available under the Transfer of Property Act, 1882.

Khurana said more than 500 members of the Delhi Gymkhana Club supported the lawsuit. It seeks to restrain the Central government from "illegally determining" the Gymkhana Club's perpetual leasehold rights and to prevent any forced dispossession from the historic premises situated on 2, Safdarjung Road, adjacent to the prime minister's residence on Lok Kalyan Marg.

The lawsuit said urgent interim protection was necessary in this case, claiming that the Centre has threatened to take possession of the plot of land on June 5 through "coercive measures" and police assistance, which will result in an "irreversible" and "irreparable" situation.

In the lawsuit, Khurana emphasised that the Delhi Gymkhana Club and its members have invested substantial resources towards the development, maintenance and modernisation of the club, and the Centre was seeking to

dismantle its institutional existence and irretrievably extinguish the "valuable associational, participatory and membership rights accrued over decades".

He also asserted that the Centre's notice, dated May 22, neither provides for any compensation nor does it establish a "bona fide public purpose" in terms of the perpetual lease deed to unilaterally extinguish "century-old" rights.

The lawsuit argued that the Centre's decision is in flagrant violation of Article 300A of the Constitution, as the record showed that the Delhi Gymkhana Club has proprietary rights over the land, which cannot be taken away arbitrarily without an acquisition process and payment of compensation. Article 300A states that no person can be deprived of his property except by authority of law.

"The uninterrupted recognition of Defendant No. 2's (Delhi Gymkhana Club) perpetual leasehold rights for nearly a century, coupled with continued acceptance of rent and performance of contractual obligations, created a legitimate expectation of continuity and non-arbitrary treatment," the lawsuit, filed through lawyer Naman Joshi, said.

"Having already exercised deep and pervasive control over the governance and functioning of Defendant No. 2 through government-appointed nominees, Defendant No. 1 (Centre) has now sought, through the impugned notice, to assume complete control and possession of the suit property itself.

Cinema legend Dharmendra honoured...

Indian women's cricket team captain Harmanpreet Kaur Bhullar, actor Prosenjit Chatterjee, para athlete Praveen Kumar and former Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) director general K Vijay Kumar received the Padma Shri.

For 2026, the President has approved conferment of 131 Padma Awards — five Padma Vibhushan, 13 Padma Bhushan and 113 Padma Shri. The awards will be conferred at two separate Civil Investiture ceremonies.

The Padma Awards are announced on the occasion of the Republic Day every year. The coveted civilian honours are given in various fields, including art, social work, public affairs, science and engineering, trade and industry, medicine, literature and education, sports and civil service.

AIADMK hit by fresh exodus

With Speaker JCD Prabhakar accepting the resignation of the three MLAs, the strength of the AIADMK has dropped to 44 from 47 in the 234-member Assembly. The Speaker said the ECI will be communicated on the resignation. Soon after meeting the Speaker, the three legislators — Maragatham Kumaravel, P Sathyabama and S Jayakumar, met senior TVK leader and PWD Minister Aadhav Arjuna. Kumaravel said, "We are going to join TVK in Panayur (party hq)," later in the day. With the Speaker accepting the resignations, Tamil Nadu will witness byelections to four Assembly constituencies including the Tiruchirappalli East vacated by Vijay.

Modi averted fuel shortage amid global crisis, claims BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Monday slammed Rahul Gandhi for his comments on the recent spree of fuel price hikes, accusing the Congress leader of attempting to undermine the country.

This response followed Gandhi's scathing attack on Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the latest fuel hike, in which he said '*mehangai manav* ' has struck again, stating that Modi's only role is to make promises during elections while attacking people's pockets at other times.

Petrol and diesel prices were raised by ₹2.61-2.71 per litre on Monday, marking the fourth increase in less than two weeks as State-owned fuel retailers continued to pass on rising international oil prices to consumers.

Reacting sharply to Gandhi's remarks, BJP national spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia called the Congress leader "foolish, immature,



BJP national spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia

and anarchic," alleging that "the leader of the opposition is attempting to weaken the country."

Bhatia highlighted that oil and diesel prices have surged significantly worldwide; however, India's price increases have been modest in comparison, particularly when viewed alongside those in the US, UK, and Gulf nations.

"Rahul Gandhi, if your motive is to spread anarchy, we are also determined to make India stronger," the BJP spokesperson told a press

conference at the party headquarters.

He added that India is effectively addressing this global challenge under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, emphasising that the country's economy is strong and that the people support the Modi Government. Bhatia claimed that petrol prices have risen by 58 per cent in Malaysia, 46 per cent in the US, 34 per cent in Canada, 25 per cent in China, and 20 per cent in the UK, while in India, they have only increased by 5.5 per

cent thus far. "For nearly 65 to 70 days, a war-like situation persisted, yet in India, petrol prices did not rise even by ₹1. The primary reason for this was the Government's intent that no burden should fall on the common man," he said.

Bhatia said the Government took "concrete steps" in the interest of the people of India, while oil companies "accepted" the losses. It was ensured that the common people did not suffer, he added.

"Another important truth is that, even after 75 days, there is no shortage of petrol and diesel in the country, and these fuels remain available in the market. While there is a global crisis regarding gas, India has prioritised domestic gas, ensuring its availability," the BJP spokesperson said. Bhatia mentioned that over the past 80 days, inflation has sharply increased in many countries, while in India it has remained around 4 per cent.

Pradhan writes to CMs for smooth conduct of NEET-UG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Monday wrote to chief ministers, lieutenant governors and administrators of States and Union Territories, seeking their cooperation for the smooth and fair conduct of the NEET-UG re-examination scheduled on June 21.

In view of the prevailing heatwave conditions, Pradhan urged States and UTs to ensure the availability of essential facilities at examination centres for the convenience and well-being of candidates, the Education Ministry said in a statement.

"In view of the prevailing heatwave conditions, I request you to kindly issue appropriate instructions to the district authorities and all schools, colleges, uni-



versities and other institutions hosting the examination in your State/UT to ensure the availability of essential basic amenities for the convenience of candidates," he said in the letter.

The minister explained that these facilities may include safe drinking water, adequate seating arrangements,

functional fans and coolers, clean washrooms, shaded waiting areas, uninterrupted electricity supply and portable toilets wherever required.

Emphasising that the well-being of students was of paramount importance, Pradhan called on State Governments to ensure adequate transportation facilities for candidates on the day of the examination.

He expressed confidence that all States and UTs would extend full cooperation to ensure that the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination is conducted in a smooth, transparent and fair manner.

The National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate) for admissions in medical courses held on May 3 was cancelled by the National Testing Agency (NTA) on May 12 amid allegations of paper leak.

NIA raids Kashmir locations in Jamaat terror-funding case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

The National Investigation Agency on Monday conducted searches in the Kashmir Valley as part of its probe into a terror-funding case linked to the banned Jamaat-e-Islami.

The searches, conducted at three locations in Srinagar and Shopian districts of Kashmir, led to the recovery of several incriminating financial documents and electronic gadgets suspected to be related to the activities of Jamaat-e-Islami (JeI) and its various trusts/associations in J&K.

Officers of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) carried out searches at the Darul Uloom Sirajul Uloom, a school in the Imam Sahib area of Shopian, which was declared an "illegal entity" last month, official sources said.

Searches were also conducted at the residence of the former JeI chief, Shahzada Aurangzeb, at Molu Chitragam in the district, and at the Jamiat ul Banaat, a religious school for girls in Srinagar's Lal Bazar area.

The federal anti-terror agency has been probing the separatist and secessionist activities of JeI, declared an unlawful association under



the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act.

The investigations so far have revealed that JeI was actively involved in collecting terror funds and fuelling terrorism in the Valley and other parts of India.

"It was engaged in collecting funds domestically and internationally in the name of donations for charity and welfare activities, such as health and education.

"It was diverting such funds towards violent and secessionist activities, and also channelling them to proscribed terrorist organisations such as the Hizbul-Mujahideen (HM) and others through well-organised networks of cadres," an NIA statement said.

The JeI terror conspiracy also involved radicalisation and recruitment of impressionable Kashmiri youth as new members ('Rukuns') for carrying out secessionist activities, it said.

Quad Foreign Ministers to focus on Indo-Pacific, West Asia

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

The economic impact of the ongoing West Asia crisis, the evolving security landscape in the Indo-Pacific, and measures to strengthen cooperation in critical minerals and technology are expected to dominate discussions at the crucial meeting of Quad foreign ministers scheduled for Tuesday in New Delhi.

The meeting will bring together External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Australian Foreign Minister Penny Wong, and Japanese Foreign Minister Toshimitsu Motegi.

The Quad grouping — comprising India, the United States, Australia and Japan — has increasingly emerged as a major strategic platform focused on ensuring peace, stability and security in the Indo-Pacific region. India is hosting the meeting as the current chair of the coalition.

The ministerial dialogue comes nearly a year after the previous Quad foreign ministers' meeting held in Washington DC.

According to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), the discussions will primarily focus on advancing the Quad's shared vision for a "free and open Indo-Pacific." The ministers are expected to review the progress of ongoing initiatives, enhance cooperation in priority sectors, and exchange views on recent regional and global developments.

People familiar with the prepa-



rations said the leaders are likely to deliberate on pressing international challenges, including the conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia, while also reviewing the security situation in the Indo-Pacific amid growing Chinese assertiveness in the region.

Over the past few years, the Quad has launched several initiatives aimed at addressing key regional challenges, particularly in maritime security, infrastructure development, connectivity, and emerging technologies.

At the last Quad summit held in Wilmington, United States, in 2024, leaders of the four-member group-

ing announced significant steps to expand maritime security cooperation across the Indo-Pacific.

Tuesday's meeting is also expected to help shape the agenda for the next Quad summit, which is likely to be hosted by India later this year.

Speaking after bilateral talks with Jaishankar on Saturday, Rubio described the Quad as a vital mechanism for strategic coordination.

"The Quad is a forum of alignment between four countries which are strategically aligned on key issues and have the ability to influence global events on matters of mutual interest," Rubio said during a media briefing.

MPs grill oil ministry officials over fuel shortage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Several members of a parliamentary panel on Monday grilled officials of the Oil ministry over "long queues" and "rationing" of petrol and diesel at petrol pumps in some parts of the country, and were informed by the officials that the country had crude oil stocks for the next 78 days, sources said.

The officials told the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture, which met to discuss the impact of

the suffering of common people due to high oil and fertiliser prices.

The officials of the Shipping Ministry informed the Parliamentary Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture that as many as 37 Indian ships were stranded in West Asia in March and 13 are still stuck due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, amid uncertainty over the end of the war, the sources said.

The Fertiliser Ministry officials are also learnt to have informed the parliamentary panel members that



the West Asia crisis on maritime trade, that 13 Indian ships continued to be stranded in West Asia due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, they said.

The Government has made efforts to ensure there is no shortage. However, the uncertainty on when the war would end continues, the officials told the panel.

Raising with officials of the Oil ministry the issue of "shortage" of petrol and LPG, some Opposition members pointed out that the Oil ministry did not provide any official data to them, the sources said.

Some Opposition MPs also sought to know why corrective measures were not taken in advance, knowing that the West Asia war would not end soon. Some members told the officials that they should have planned to mitigate

there is no shortage of fertilisers in the country ahead of the Kharif sowing and the Government has made alternative arrangements.

The sources said that when some Opposition members raised the issue of high global prices of fertilisers, the officials informed the panel that the Government has procured around 80 lakh tonnes of fertilisers from alternative sources.

At present, the demand is to the tune of 78 lakh tonnes of fertilisers, which was being met, the sources added.

The panel had arranged a meeting with the officials of the Ministry of Shipping, Petroleum and Fertilisers. Secretary, Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Vijay Kumar, made a presentation before the panel members on the steps taken by the Ministry.

States Focus



GOVT BOOSTING HEALTHCARE VIA YOGA, SAYS PRATAPRAO

Union Ayush Minister Prataprao Jadhav on Monday said yoga and naturopathy are increasingly being recognised as effective complementary approaches for managing non-communicable diseases and mental health disorders, thereby supporting preventive and integrative healthcare. Jadhav made the remarks as he chaired the fourth meeting of the Parliamentary Consultative Committee of the Ministry of Ayush.

The meeting focused on "Yoga and Naturopathy in India" and deliberated on the Government's initiatives to strengthen preventive healthcare, wellness promotion and the global outreach of India's traditional systems of healthcare, an Ayush Ministry statement said.



KERALA CM TO MEET PM MODI AND FM SITHARAMAN

Kerala Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan will meet Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman in New Delhi on Tuesday, in his first official meetings with the two leaders after taking office. According to the schedule, Satheesan will meet the Prime Minister at 11.15 am at Seva Teerth in New Delhi. Later in the day, the chief minister, who also handles the finance portfolio, is scheduled to meet the Union Finance Minister at 2.30 pm at Kartavya Bhavan. The meetings are expected to focus on key issues concerning Kerala, including financial matters and development projects, sources said.

MP High Court issues notice to actress Twisha's mother-in-law



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

The Madhya Pradesh High Court has issued a notice to retired judge Giribala Singh, mother-in-law of actress Twisha Sharma, in connection with the ongoing investigation into the actress's death. The notice was issued on a petition filed by the Madhya Pradesh Government and Twisha's father, Navnidhi Sharma, challenging the anticipatory bail granted to Giribala Singh by a trial court.

During Monday's hearing, Advocate General Prashant Singh, appearing for the State Government, told the court that Giribala Singh was not cooperating with the investigation. Opposing the claim, Giribala Singh's counsel, Mrigendra Singh, argued that the allegation was incorrect and maintained that the family had been cooperating with investigators.

NMCG pushes circular water model to reuse wastewater

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Mission for Clean Ganga has said that treated wastewater is increasingly being reused for industrial and non-potable purposes under the national framework for safe reuse of treated water, positioning sewage as a "resource" instead of merely a disposal problem.

In a post on X on Monday, the Mission highlighted ongoing projects where treated sewage water is replacing freshwater usage in industrial operations. "We have been thinking about sewage all wrong. For decades, treated wastewater



was something to get rid of. A by-product. A disposal problem," the post on the Namami Gange handle of the Mission said.

"NMCG flipped that. Under the national framework for safe reuse of treated water,

sewage that has been treated is now a resource, and it is already replacing freshwater in places where freshwater should never have been wasted on," it added.

According to the Mission under the Ministry of Jal

Shakti, 8 million litres per day (MLD) of treated water from the Trans Yamuna sewage treatment plant (STP) is being supplied to the Mathura Refinery for industrial use.

It also cited the reuse of treated wastewater by the Pragati Power Corporation in Delhi and the Jobbera Thermal Power Plant in Jharkhand for thermal and operational purposes using water sourced from nearby STPs.

The NMCG said the framework promotes the use of treated wastewater in industrial, agricultural and other non-potable sectors to reduce the extraction of freshwater from rivers and groundwater sources.

PM pollution jumps over 20 per cent in Indo-Gangetic plain, NE, Himalayas: Study

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The overall particulate matter pollution in the Indo-Gangetic Plain, the Himalayan region, and North-East India increased by more than 20 per cent during the 2010-2019 period compared to the 2000-2009 baseline, according to a new study.

It also revealed that in the eastern Indo-Gangetic Plain, carbonaceous aerosols, particles from the burning of crop residue, wood, and other organic material, showed strong and increas-



ing trends between 2000 and 2024 (the period the study analysed).

According to the study, the sharp rise in particulate matter (PM) in North-East India is attributed to intensi-

fied slash-and-burn agricultural practices and extensive use of biomass for domestic energy in rural households during this period.

The study, "Decadal shifts in aerosol hotspots and source

attribution over IGP, north-east India and Himalayas: A 25-year (2000-2024) study", was published in the journal Atmospheric Environment and released on Monday.

In a statement, Abhijit Chatterjee, co-author of the study and professor at the Bose Institute in Kolkata, said, "The eastern Indo-Gangetic Plain, and increasingly North-East India, are carrying a disproportionate pollution burden, and it is being driven almost entirely by biomass burning. That is the signal that stands out most clearly across 25 years of data."



States Focus



ANDHRA CM LAUNCHES MSME SUMMIT, 38 MSME PARKS

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Monday inaugurated the One Family-One Entrepreneur MSME growth summit 2026 in Vijayawada and laid the foundation stone virtually for 38 MSME parks. He also announced measures to strengthen the sector. On the occasion, the Government entered into agreements with companies such as Meta, Amazon and Zoho to promote investment and entrepreneurship. More than 1,500 participants, including Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME) industrialists, PM Vishwakarma beneficiaries, policymakers, representatives of financial institutions and technical experts from across Andhra Pradesh, attended the programme.



RAJASTHAN CM LAUNCHES WATER CONSERVATION DRIVE

Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma launched the 'Vande Ganga Jal Sanrakshan Jan Abhiyan' from the Baisalpur Dam on Monday, coinciding with Ganga Dussehra. According to an official statement, the statewide campaign will run from May 25 to June 5 and will include awareness drives and activities focused on water conservation. The chief minister performed traditional rituals at the dam and urged people to participate in water conservation efforts actively. He also visited the Baisaldeo Mahadev Temple and offered prayers. Sharma said the State Government had undertaken similar initiatives last year, focusing on the cleaning and preservation of water bodies such as ponds, lakes and reservoirs.

3,200 communal posts removed in Manipur: DGP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

Manipur Director General of Police (DGP) Rajiv Singh on Monday said 5,406 sensitive, violent and communal posts have been identified and around 3,200 taken down since June 2023, a month after ethnic violence erupted, while 187 pages and accounts have been blocked.

He said the action was taken in coordination with the state IT Department and the Centre's Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY).

Speaking at a programme in which 477 police vehicles, including armoured cars and two-wheelers, were flagged off by Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh at the 1st Manipur Rifles Ground, the DGP said, "Since June 1, 2023, a total of 5,406 sensitive, violent and communal posts were identified, and around 3,200 posts were taken down in coordination with the state IT department and MeitY. A total of 187 pages and accounts were also blocked."



The DGP said prevention, monitoring and verification of fake news and misinformation were needed to ensure public order.

"The social media outreach of Manipur Police, which clears doubts and issues clarifications, has also expanded significantly. Its Facebook followers have increased to 79,000 and X followers to 27,000," the officer said.

"When I took charge as the DGP of Manipur Police in June 2023, the State was passing through one of the most difficult and challenging times in its history due to the vio-

Assam Assembly tables UCC Bill to ban polygamy

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Assam Government on Monday tabled a Bill on the Uniform Civil Code, seeking to ban polygamy and make registration of live-in relationships compulsory.

The Bill, however, said that it will not be applicable to any of the Scheduled Tribes residing in Assam.

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Atul Bora tabled 'The Uniform Civil Code, Assam, 2026 Bill' in the Assembly on behalf of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma.

The Opposition parties, including Congress, Rajior Dal and Trinamool Congress,

opposed the move and demanded wider consultation with all the stakeholders before its introduction.

"The Bill aims to consolidate and simplify laws governing marriage, divorce, succession, and live-in relationships," Sarma said in the 'Statement of Object and Reasons' in the Bill.

For marriage, the Bill sets 21 years and 18 years as minimum age for men and women respectively, and prohibits polygamy, he added.

"Importantly, it protects Assam's cultural diversity by allowing marriages to be performed according to existing religious and customary



Assam Minister Atul Bora tabled the Uniform Civil Code Bill on behalf of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma

rites," Sarma said. To safeguard legal rights, the Bill proposes to make marriage and divorce registration compulsory, which will be vital for

securing maintenance, inheritance and other legal protection for spouses.

"For the first time, the Bill provides a legal framework

for live-in relationships. By requiring registration, the law ensures that the rights of partners — and any children born from such unions — are formally recognised and protected," the CM said in the Bill.

He further said that UCC aims to modernise succession laws to ensure a fair and equal distribution of property.

"It introduces uniform rules for inheritance, ensuring that the transfer of assets is handled justly for all residents of the State," Sarma stated.

It also proposed to establish necessary administrative machinery, including the

appointment of registrars, to implement the reforms.

"This ensures that the code is not just a policy but a practical tool for social justice and equality in Assam," Sarma said.

"The Constitution, under Article 44, directs the State to strive for a Uniform Civil Code for its citizens. This Bill seeks to implement this principle within Assam to ensure a common legal framework for all residents, regardless of their religion," Sarma said.

By creating a uniform system, the code ensures legal clarity and protects the fundamental rights of every individual, he added.

Congress demands Pradhan's resignation over CBSE glitches

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With the CBSE set to engage IIT-Madras and IIT-Kanpur experts to address technical challenges in its post-result services portal, the Congress on Monday attacked the Government, saying the "Mantri Pradhan" should step down and the 'Pradhan Mantri' owed people an explanation for why the minister was being allowed to continue.

Congress general secretary in-charge of communications, Jairam Ramesh, said the CBSE introduced an On-Screen Marking (OSM) system for Class 12 board examinations, which has thrown into chaos the academic futures of lakhs of children across the country.

"The Grade 12 pass percentage has declined by an unprecedented 3 percentage points (from 88 per cent to 85 per cent), and the process has been plagued by irregularities — blurred and illegible answer sheets, erroneous marking, incorrect answer sheets being attributed to students, payment



Congress leader Jairam Ramesh

delays, and outrageous revaluation fees being demanded from students," Ramesh said on X.

The education minister, who is presiding over "total institutional collapse", has finally woken up to this "tragedy" more than a week after it first came to light, the Congress leader said.

"He's portraying himself as some saviour by bringing in IIT-Kanpur to help address these technical issues. The question really is, why were these issues not anticipated? Why did the CBSE and the ministry not plan carefully before adopting this OSM system? Why did it take the minister so long to respond to this issue?" Ramesh said. "The Mantri Pradhan owes

the country his resignation, and the Pradhan Mantri owes us answers to why this minister — who is openly disrupting the future of India's students with his ineptitude — has been allowed to continue for so long," he said.

The education ministry on Sunday said that the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) will engage experts from the Indian Institute of Technology, Madras, and IIT-Kanpur to address technical challenges in its post-result services portal. The move comes amid complaints from students and parents over glitches in the CBSE re-evaluation process. The ministry said Union Education Minister Dharmendra

Eight killed as SUV falls into deep gorge in Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Eight persons were killed after a Sport Utility Vehicle (SUV) plunged over 1,000 feet into a gorge in Maharashtra's Raigad district, officials said on Monday.

The accident occurred in the Ambenali Ghat area on Poladpur-Mahabaleshwar road, located about 180 km from Mumbai, between 5 am and 6 am on Sunday, when the victims were on their way from Dapoli to Satara. The vehicle was found in the gorge on Monday morning, a senior police official said.

The victims, in the age group of 19 to 35, left from Harne in Dapoli at around 2 am on Sunday in the SUV.

When they did not reach Satara, their relatives launched a search in the afternoon and later approached the police.

During the investigation, the victims' last location



was traced through a mobile tower near Poladpur. While searching in the Ambenali Ghat section, the police spotted the SUV in the deep gorge on Monday morning, the official said.

The police suspect that the accident occurred after the driver lost control of the vehicle in the ghat area, following which it plunged into the gorge, he said.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis expressed grief over the death of eight persons and said rescue operations were being carried out on a war footing. The eight friends were on a

trip when their vehicle plunged nearly 1,500 feet into a gorge in the hilly stretch, he said in a statement.

The district administration launched immediate rescue and relief operations and formed five teams of seven members each to retrieve the bodies, the CM informed.

Three bodies had been recovered so far, while efforts were underway to retrieve the remaining bodies with the help of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and voluntary rescue teams, he said.

Bihar CM hails inclusion of Maithili language in CBSE curriculum

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Monday hailed the decision to include Maithili in the CBSE curriculum at the secondary level from the next academic session.

The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) has decided to introduce Maithili as a subject at the secondary level from the 2026-27 session.

"Inclusion of the Maithili language in the CBSE curriculum from class 1 up to the secondary level is a matter of pride for Mithila's cultural identity and linguistic glory," Choudhary said in a post on X. He termed the move aimed at preserving Mithila's rich cultural heritage through the education system as "historic" and "highly commendable".

Ladakh LG launches portal to boost ease of doing business

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Leh/Jammu

Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Monday launched an integrated 'ease-of-doing business' portal for Ladakh, describing it as a major step towards strengthening digital governance, improving service delivery and creating a business-friendly ecosystem in the Union Territory. The portal - <https://eodb.ladakh.gov.in> - is aimed at simplifying access to Government services by reducing manual procedures, paperwork and delays in approvals through a single online platform, officials said.

The platform will also provide entrepreneurs, investors, startups, micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) and other stakeholders with a unified mechanism to avail Government services and approvals online.



Officials said the initiative is aligned with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of "ease of doing business" and "minimum Government, maximum governance", and is expected to enhance transparency, efficiency and accountability, while promoting economic growth and investment in the Union Territory.

In the first phase, 13 departments have been integrated with the portal and 23 online services have already been

made operational, officials said. The administration plans to expand the platform by onboarding more departments and services in a phased manner.

The portal currently offers access to services from departments, including Tourism, Public Health Engineering, and Industries and Commerce, besides providing information on Government schemes, incentives, policies, Acts, rules, notifications and procedures.

Himachal: BJP alleges Congress Govt interfering in local polls

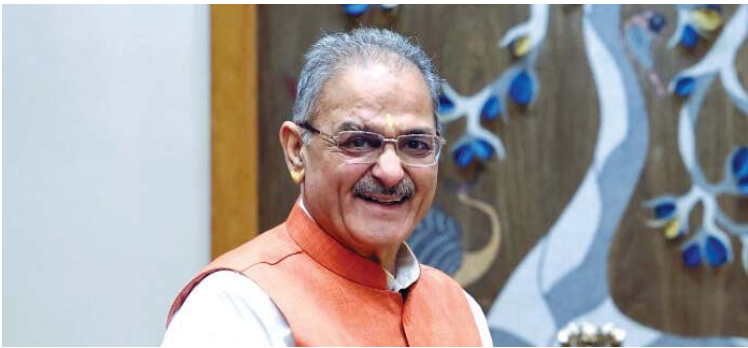
PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Shimla

Raising concerns of alleged interference in rural and urban local body elections by the Congress Government, a delegation of the BJP met Governor Kavinder Gupta on Monday, seeking his intervention in the matter.

The BJP, led by State president Rajeev Bindal, submitted a memorandum to the governor, alleging that the Sukhvinder Sukhu-led Government was attempting to manipulate democratic processes, amend rules, and influence the public mandate through administrative and political pressure, after sensing defeat in the elections.

Elections for 51 urban local bodies were held on March 17, while polling in 3,754 gram panchayats would be conducted in three phases on May 26, 28 and 30. Leader of Opposition and former chief minister Jairam Thakur was also present in the meeting, along with several senior BJP leaders and other office bearers.

Addressing the media, Bindal said the BJP delegation approached the governor to "protect democracy and constitutional values in



Governor of Himachal Pradesh Kavinder Gupta

Himachal Pradesh". He alleged that amendments in reservation-related provisions and changes in rules governing the election of chairpersons and vice-chairpersons of municipal councils and nagar panchayats were aimed at giving excessive discretionary powers to officials and indirectly benefiting Congress leaders through backdoor political influence.

Bindal said the Congress had failed to officially nominate candidates in several places due to fear of defeat.

He claimed that the Government had earlier tried to delay panchay-

at elections but failed in both the high court and the Supreme Court, and that the elections were now being conducted only because of the apex court directives.

Thakur also accused Chief Minister Sukhvinder Sukhu of openly violating the Model Code of Conduct by announcing financial incentives and development funds during election rallies in favour of Congress-backed candidates.

He said announcements ranging from ₹50 lakh to ₹1 crore for development works were made publicly, amounting to a direct violation of

election norms. He also claimed that the BJP-supported candidates were in the majority in 18 out of 25 municipal councils and 12 out of 22 nagar panchayats, saying that after witnessing the results, the Congress Government amended rules related to the election of chairpersons and vice-chairpersons to delay the process and create possibilities for political pressure and horse-trading.

Thakur alleged that elected representatives were being threatened with vigilance inquiries, transfers, and administrative action if they did not support Congress-backed groups.

The senior BJP leader claimed that Cabinet decisions taken during the enforcement of the Model Code of Conduct, including announcements related to financial assistance schemes and honorarium hikes, were intended to influence voters and elected representatives.

The BJP delegation urged the governor to intervene and ensure the protection of democratic values, constitutional processes, and the sanctity of the people's mandate in Himachal Pradesh.

India faced pseudo war with China in Op Sindoor: Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Monday said India faced a “pseudo war” with China during Operation Sindoor as that nation supplied arms and provided logistical backing to Pakistan during the conflict.

Indian-made drones and missiles demonstrated their precision and prowess during the conflict, which took place between May 7 and 10 last year, while Chinese-made drones and missiles (used by Pakistan) could not hit our targets and were neutralised by our air defence system, the CM said at an event marking 12 years of Narendra Modi’s prime ministership.

“During Operation Sindoor, India showed its military prowess. India was not only fighting against Pakistan, but we were also engaged in a pseudo-war with China. Pakistan received arms and all types of logistical support



from China,” Fadnavis said.

India had undergone a major transformation under Modi’s leadership and moved from a “culture of waiting for favours” to one of confidence and self-reliance, Fadnavis added.

He said India’s GDP had increased from ₹103 lakh crore around 12 years ago to ₹357 lakh crore now, while Maharashtra’s gross state domestic product had risen from ₹13 lakh crore to ₹54

lakh crore during the same period. “The previous UPA regime believed in keeping people dependent on subsidies instead of creating opportunities, whereas the Modi Government expanded the economy, attracted investments and focused on last-mile delivery of welfare schemes. The Centre’s thrust on infrastructure through Bharatmala and Sagarmala has significantly reduced logistics costs and strength-

ened India’s position in the global supply chain,” he said.

With logistics costs steadily declining, India can compete with China in supply chain replacement and emerge as a major player in the world supply chain, the CM added.

The chief minister also accused the earlier UPA Government of neglecting road infrastructure near border areas due to fears that China could use these in the event of a conflict.

Quoting a Northern Command officer, Fadnavis said the earlier Government was reluctant to build roads close to the borders, while the present dispensation created infrastructure networks enabling artillery and military supplies to reach border areas within hours.

Referring to maritime infrastructure, he said the upcoming Vadhavan port project in Palghar district would emerge among the world’s top 10 ports from the very beginning.

BJD MP Debashish Samantaray quits party; likely to join BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

BJD Rajya Sabha MP Debashish Samantaray on Monday resigned from the primary membership of the party, alleging that he was being “systematically belittled”.

In a letter to party chief Naveen Patnaik, Samantaray said, “I do hereby resign from the primary membership of BJD. Of late, I felt I have been systematically belittled in the party and that it does not require my services.

Therefore, I have taken this hard decision in the public interest and request you to accept my resignation.”

Samantaray’s resignation comes months after two other Rajya Sabha MPs — Sujeet Kumar and Mamata



Mahanta — quit the party. Mahanta and Kumar were later elected to the Rajya Sabha on BJP tickets.

A two-time MLA elected in 2009 and 2014, Samantaray expressed gratitude to Patnaik for nominating him to the Upper House of Parliament.

“I shall always be indebted to you for nominating me to the Rajya Sabha. I take this opportunity to express my

sincere and deepest gratitude to you for giving me the opportunity to serve the people of the undivided Cuttack district and to raise issues concerning Odisha at the national level,” he said in the letter.

Sources said Samantray was likely to join the BJP.

Samantaray, who was elected to the Rajya Sabha in April 2024, had been a known critic of former bureaucrat-turned-politician VK Pandian, who withdrew from active politics after the BJP’s defeat in the 2024 Lok Sabha and Odisha Assembly elections.

He had repeatedly alleged that despite announcing his “sanyas” from active politics, Pandian continued to influence the functioning of the regional party from behind the scenes.

Ensure welfare reaches grassroots: Rijiju to BJP workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

Union minister Kiren Rijiju on Monday called upon BJP workers to work with dedication, discipline and a clear vision to ensure the all-round development of Arunachal Pradesh, while stressing the need to strengthen grassroots-level activities and effectively implement welfare schemes for the benefit of the people.

Addressing party leaders and workers during the Deendayal Upadhyaya Prashikshan Maha Abhiyan, organised for Lower Siang and Leparada districts at Basar, Rijiju, the Union Minority and Parliamentary Affairs minister said the BJP Governments at the Centre and in the State have ushered in significant development and launched

Karnataka hotels warn of food price hike after wage revision

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Karnataka State Hotels Association on Monday warned that the State Government’s decision to implement revised minimum wages will lead to a steep rise in food prices across hotels and restaurants.

Noting that the average minimum wage increase is about 60 per cent from the current wages and will severely impact restaurants, association president GK Shetty said a plate of Idli may jump to ₹80 from the present ₹50 and Masala Dosa to ₹150 from ₹80-90.

Vegetarian meals priced at ₹150-200 may rise to ₹250-300, and biryani dishes in Bengaluru could increase from ₹300-350 to nearly ₹500, he said, adding that, “With such increases, eating out will become more expensive for ordinary citizens, impacting the hotel industry.”

Karnataka has notified new minimum wages for



organised and unorganised sectors. As per this, an unskilled person should be paid ₹23,376 per month in the Greater Bengaluru Area, and for a highly skilled worker, it has been fixed at ₹31,114 per month. Outside Bengaluru, the minimum wage for unskilled work ranges from ₹19,300 to ₹21,251.

Shetty said that the nearly 60 per cent increase in minimum wages would significantly raise operating costs for hotels, particularly small and family-run establishments already

struggling with rising expenses.

The price of a commercial LPG cylinder had been hiked from ₹1,884 to ₹3,152 in just a few months. All the groceries, power tariffs & garbage cess rates were also hiked, adding to the strain of small hoteliers, he said in a release. Shetty pointed out that the hotel sector already provides several welfare benefits to workers, including food, accommodation, uniforms and washing allowances, unlike many other industries.

Gujarat on high alert over Ebola

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

The Gujarat Government has stepped up surveillance and preparedness measures following reports of Ebola cases in parts of Africa, even as officials confirmed that no case has been detected in India so far.

State Health Minister Praful Pansheriya reassured citizens that there is no cause for panic, emphasising that the health department is fully equipped to handle any potential situation. He noted that guidelines and standard operating procedures issued by the central health authorities are being strictly implemented across the State.

The alert comes amid reports of Ebola infections in countries such as Uganda, Democratic Republic of the Congo, and South Sudan.

A high-level review meeting chaired by the minister was held at Swarnim Sankul-2 in Gandhinagar.

Gujarat MPs spent just 21% of local development funds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Ahmedabad

Concerns over low utilisation of development funds have emerged in Gujarat, where several Members of Parliament have spent only a fraction of the grants allocated under the Member of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme (MPLADS).

Among them, Ahmedabad West MP Dinesh Makwana has utilised only Rs 80 lakh out of ₹16.04 crore sanctioned to him, placing him among the lowest spenders in the State. Similarly, Gandhinagar MP and Union Home Minister Amit Shah has spent ₹41.47 lakh from an allocation of ₹14.70 crore. Under MPLADS, each MP is entitled to Rs 5 crore annually for recommending local development works, amounting to roughly ₹25 crore over a five-year term. However, figures indicate that Gujarat’s 26 MPs have collectively



utilised only ₹82.87 crore out of ₹384 crore allocated so far — just about 21 per cent.

In contrast, Bharuch MP Mansukh Vasava has recorded the highest utilisation, spending ₹5.75 crore (around 39.13 per cent) of his allocation. Patan MP Bharatsinh Dabhi follows with ₹5.57 crore spent, while Amreli MP Bharat Sutariya has utilised ₹5.08 crore.

Karnataka Govt to review guarantee scheme beneficiaries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Monday said the Government is considering reviewing its list of beneficiaries for the guarantee schemes by asking them to resubmit their documents, as crores of rupees are being diverted to ineligible recipients.

He was responding to a question about plans to review the guarantee schemes, as ineligible people are receiving the benefits.

“A number of beneficiaries have died, and around ₹100 crore is going to ineligible recipients, resulting in misuse. We have records of this. Also, beneficiaries have given someone else’s phone numbers in many cases, so we need to know whether the benefits are reaching the right beneficiaries,” Shivakumar said.

Speaking to reporters, he said, “Lots of discussions have happened, and suggestions have come to ask the beneficiaries to once again submit their doc-



uments properly. We have got information of about ₹100 crore with the Gruh Lakshmi scheme alone. We are reviewing every taluk and gathering information.” In 2026-27, the Government has allocated ₹51,286 crore for the five schemes.

The Congress Government’s five guarantee schemes are -200 units of free power to all households (Gruha

lyoti), ₹2,000 monthly assistance to the woman head of every family (Gruha Lakshmi), the additional 5 kg of rice to every member of a BPL household (Anna Bhagya), ₹3,000 every month for unemployed graduate youth and ₹1,500 for diploma holders for two years (YuvaNidhi), and free travel for women in public transport buses (Shakti).

Kapurthala jail clash: 31 inmates booked for rioting and arson

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

As many as 31 inmates have been booked on various charges, including rioting and arson, in connection with a clash inside the Kapurthala Central Jail that left three injured, a senior police official said on Monday.

Police had lobbed teargas shells and resorted to a cane charge after inmates of Block-4 in the prison clashed on Saturday night.

Senior Superintendent of Police, Kapurthala, Gaurav Toora, said 31 inmates have been booked on the charges of rioting, arson, attempt to murder, obstructing public servants from performing their duties and criminal conspiracy.

They have also been booked under relevant sections of the Information Technology Act and the



Prisons Act, he said. During the clash, the inmates tried to manhandle and scuffle with the officials. Some inmates even set something on fire outside their barracks. They had reached the roof of their barracks after breaking a gate and an iron grill leading to the rooftop, according to police.

While two inmates were injured in the clash, another sustained injury after he was hit by a teargas shell, police

had said. No police personnel or jail staff were injured in the clash.

Police on Sunday seized iron rods, sticks and mobile phones from inmates who ran amok in the jail.

Opposition parties have attacked the Bhagwant Mann Government over the Kapurthala jail incident, saying it has once again exposed the collapsing law and order situation in the State.

Over 27,000 manuscripts digitised in Haryana

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

A total of 27,587 manuscripts have been uploaded in Haryana under the Gyan Bharatam Mission, marking a major step towards preserving the State’s rich documentary and intellectual heritage, officials said.

The initiative is expected to create a comprehensive digital repository that will significantly contribute towards preserving India’s knowledge systems and making them accessible to scholars, researchers and future generations worldwide.

Among the districts, Kurukshetra emerged as the top-performing district with 15,818 manuscripts uploaded on the Gyan Bharatam portal so far.

Haryana Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi here on Monday reviewed the progress of the National Manuscript Survey and directed departments to further accelerate outreach



and documentation efforts across the State.

During the review meeting, the chief secretary assessed the ongoing implementation of the survey across districts and emphasised the need for coordinated efforts among Government departments, educational institutions and district administrations to ensure comprehensive documentation of valuable manuscripts available across Haryana.

Rastogi stressed that the preservation of manuscripts is not merely an archival

exercise but an important initiative aimed at safeguarding centuries-old knowledge, traditions and cultural values for future generations.

He underlined that such efforts would help preserve India’s rich intellectual heritage and strengthen its accessibility for researchers and scholars.

The Gyan Bharatam Mission, a flagship initiative of the Ministry of Culture, Government of India, aims to survey, document, conserve, digitise and disseminate India’s manuscript heritage

through collaboration with academic institutions, museums, libraries and private collectors.

In addition, the National Manuscript Survey was launched on March 16, 2026, for identifying, documenting and creating a comprehensive national database of manuscripts available with institutions, private individuals, scholars, mutts, temples, libraries and other repositories.

The review highlighted that the Department of Archives, Haryana, has been designat-

ed as the State Nodal Department for implementation of the National Manuscript Survey, while a State-Level Standing Committee under the chairmanship of the chief secretary has been constituted for effective monitoring and execution of the initiative.

District-level committees and nodal officers have also been appointed across the State to facilitate the smooth implementation of the survey process.

Commissioner and Secretary, Archives Department, Saket Kumar, informed the meeting that continuous monitoring and district-level coordination are being undertaken to ensure the timely progress of the survey. The chief secretary commended the Kurukshetra district administration for its exemplary performance and urged other districts to intensify their efforts to accelerate the survey and documentation process across the State.

FOREST FIRE BREAKS OUT IN RAJOURI, VAST FOREST AREA DAMAGED

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

A major forest fire broke out in the Nowshera belt of Jammu and Kashmir’s Rajouri district on Monday, causing extensive damage to large tracts of forest land, officials said. The blaze erupted under mysterious circumstances and quickly spread to several areas in the Nowshera region, fanned by dry vegetation and prevailing weather conditions, they added.

Soon after receiving information about the incident, teams of the Forest Department, Jammu and Kashmir Fire and Emergency Services, and local volunteers launched a massive operation to contain the fire and prevent it from spreading further.



A video circulating on social media showed vast stretches of forest engulfed in flames, while the distress calls of hundreds of birds, including peacocks, could be heard in the background. The footage prompted widespread concern among residents and environmentalists, who urged authorities to intensify efforts to save wildlife and douse the flames at the earliest.

Officials informed that fire-fighting teams were working tirelessly in the difficult terrain to bring the blaze under control and safeguard the ecologically sensitive area.

The fire has destroyed large areas of plantation and other forest wealth, causing significant ecological damage, officials said, adding that no loss of human life or injury has been reported so far.



Editor's
TAKE

Repairing bridges, reaffirming alliances

Rubio's visit underscores the importance of the US-India partnership. Whether his words will translate into sustained and concrete commitments remains to be seen

Diplomacy is the deliberate act of rebuilding trust. That is precisely what Marco Rubio's four-day visit to India, which began on May 23, represents: an urgent and necessary mission to stabilise Indo-US relations that have gone through a difficult phase, as the Trump administration indulged in a series of actions that damaged the relationship, to say the least.

When a senior American diplomat arrives in India carrying a White House dinner invitation in one hand and an energy sales pitch in the other, the message is difficult to misread. Secretary of State Marco Rubio's four-day visit to India this week - covering Kolkata, Agra, Jaipur, and New Delhi - is, at its core, a damage-control exercise dressed up as strategic engagement. Washington needs New Delhi more than the optics suggest, and both sides are aware of it.

The agenda was, on paper, straightforward. Rubio was expected to discuss energy security, trade, and defence cooperation with senior Indian officials. Underlying all of it, however, was the more difficult task of rebuilding trust. Relations between the two countries have entered one of their most difficult phases in over two decades, strained by punitive tariffs and disagreements involving Pakistan, Russia, China, and regional security policy.

The immediate causes of that deficit are well known. Donald Trump imposed 50 per cent tariffs on India - ostensibly because of its purchase of Russian oil and arms. Then came the India-Pakistan military confrontation, after which Pakistan adopted a position opposite to India's, praising Trump's role in ensuring the ceasefire and even nominating him for the Nobel Peace Prize. The optics of Rubio's visit were, therefore, carefully curated. Beginning in Kolkata with a visit to the Missionaries of Charity - Mother Teresa's organisation - before proceeding to the architectural grandeur of Agra and Jaipur, and finally meeting Narendra Modi in New Delhi, conveyed a message of warmth and civilisational respect. The White House invitation delivered through Rubio to Modi added a further personal touch.

On substance, energy was the centrepiece. Rubio pressed the case for American energy exports, telling Modi that US supplies could help diversify India's energy mix - a pointed nudge away from Russian oil, framed diplomatically as diversification rather than pressure. The two sides also deliberated on the West Asia crisis and its economic implications, particularly on energy supplies, with India being especially affected by the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Strategically, the Quad ministerial meeting on May 26 gave the visit its institutional anchor. Rubio's meeting with Quad leaders will be viewed as a sign of the United States reaffirming its commitment to the Indo-Pacific region - and as a reminder to Beijing that Washington's apparent pivot towards Pakistan has not come at India's expense, even if New Delhi remains unconvinced.

The fundamentals of the US-India relationship remain intact. But goodwill is not an inexhaustible resource. Rubio's visit was a beginning, not a settlement.

NEET Leak: A national crisis of trust in education

The cancellation of NEET 2026 following allegations of a paper leak has triggered outrage and deep introspection across India. The scandal is a grim reflection of the moral and institutional decline within the country's education system



JS
RAJPUT

Professor Jayant Vishnu Narlikar, one of our most distinguished and decorated scientists, wrote an article on "Declining Work Standards" around fifteen years ago. I find it extremely relevant in comprehending the national anguish and shame being expressed following the cancellation of the NEET examination in May 2026. The learned professor wrote: "Further, our examination system has become so corrupt that we have come to accept malpractices as routine. With copying condoned even at the highest level, the examinations conducted by boards, colleges and universities are losing their credibility as a means of assessing the candidate's performance. No government, state or central, has either the will or courage to restore a sense of discipline in the system. Because of this, many specialised institutions have introduced their own entrance tests."

The National Testing Agency (NTA), created in November 2017, is one of several such bodies established during the last two to three decades. There have been serious issues of paper leakage earlier as well, including NEET-UG 2024, UGC-NET 2024, and JEE-Main 2021. The 2024 paper leak was investigated by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which enjoys nationwide credibility. Parents and the public remain unaware of what happened to the guilty and how many of them received exemplary punishment. The CBI is conducting the same exercise again for the 2026 paper leak. Media reports indicate that it has successfully unearthed the conspiracy, and that criminality will eventually be established.

Mention is being made of professors who acted as paper-setters. It must serve as an eye-opener to every teacher and academic, from schools to higher education institutions. Sadly, the entire scenario reaffirms the fact that "professions suffer credibility erosion only because of their own professionals". The credibility crisis surrounding the majority of regulatory bodies confirms this beyond any doubt.

The leakage of the NEET examination paper prior to its scheduled date of May 3, 2026, has attracted the attention of both the young and the old alike. The plight of 22.7 lakh young aspirants was indeed shocking. Most of these aspirants belong to families that could never imagine securing admission for their wards in private medical colleges. They had done their utmost in mobilising resources to enable their children to join tuition centres, coaching classes, and other support systems that claim expertise in preparing students for competitive entrance examinations. Obviously, most of these are private commercial ventures. They are well equipped with the tricks of the trade and techniques of extracting the maximum from hopeful young people and their families. There are numerous examples of entire families relocating to cities with well-advertised coaching centres. They do all of this in the hope of securing a bright



future not only for the admission seeker but for the family as a whole. The inadequacy of school education is acknowledged at every level. Consequently, parents trust private ventures as the only alternative capable of kindling hope for success, often unaware that it is ultimately a business - and business today has its own "morals and ethics". Unfortunately, this aspect hardly finds mention even in serious deliberations on how to conduct clean examinations.

Over the years, India's youth have suffered numerous instances of paper leaks, not only in examinations for admission to coveted professional courses but also in recruitment examinations for jobs. Imagine the damage that the profession and the nation would have suffered had those who purchased the paper successfully enrolled for medical degrees. The nation is generally aware of the numerous factors and forces that indulge in such immoral and unethical practices year after year, and why the system repeatedly fails to punish the guilty. Dependence on coaching institutions has increased steadily.

The neglect of quality and excellence in the majority of schools run on public finances is squarely responsible for the growth of private schools and the coaching industry. Young adolescents, after completing their first ten years of schooling, gradually realise how intense the competition will be in securing admission to reputed and affordable professional institutions. The majority of parents one interacts with remain worried and uncertain, often for several years. This does not refer to the privileged classes who are sufficiently equipped to send their wards to institutions in Western countries. There is also a subgroup that prefers institutions in Ukraine, Mauritius, and a few other destinations.

The first two or three decades after Independence were characterised by the presence of a generation that was admired throughout the country. Their lives reflected immense sacrifice and suffering endured for the freedom of the nation and for the dignified future of generations

to come. As young people in the 1950s and 1960s, many of us had the privilege of meeting freedom fighters who refused to accept pensions announced for them by governments. We learnt invaluable lessons about the nation and our obligations to society and future generations.

Those of us who received our schooling and university education during that period never experienced the anxiety of a possible paper leak before examinations. Tuitions were considered infra dig, and it was unimaginable that a college or university teacher would teach in a coaching centre. Every teacher was always willing to assist students needing support. Gradually, however, generations changed, and Gandhian values receded into the background, and elected representatives - exceptions apart - who tasted power developed their own values and norms. Adolescents and young people in schools and higher education institutions found before them a new set of icons: teachers busy with tuition classes, coaching systems, and even side businesses, while neglecting their basic moral obligations.

Most candidates appearing in entrance examinations for professional courses do so after completing school education. The undue anxiety and excessive concentration on securing higher scores often leads to insufficient emphasis during school years on the aspects necessary for holistic growth - from an innocent individual "person" into a complete "personality".

India deserves schools that embody an exemplary, morally imbued work culture. It deserves conscious teachers who remain ever aware that they themselves are the "true textbook for the pupils" and who continue as active lifelong learners. In such institutions, the entry of unscrupulous elements would become impossible. This is not a utopian wish; such schools and teachers still exist in India today.

The story of Japan's reconstruction after the Second World War demonstrates how focus on social, cultural, and moral dimensions in schools and teacher preparation institutions created professionals committed to being "true to their salt". The government and society both played their roles sincerely: schools possessed the necessary infrastructure, appropriate teacher-student ratios, and adequately trained teachers. Unfortunately, this is still not the case in India.

Those entrusted with finding better ways and means to conduct clean NEET and other entrance examinations have a difficult task ahead. It would be a humble suggestion to them to study carefully the implications and imperatives of Paragraph 15.2 of the National Education Policy 2020: "According to the Justice JS Verma Commission (2012) constituted by the Supreme Court, a majority of the stand-alone TEs - over 10,000 in number - are not even attempting serious teacher education but are essentially selling degrees for a price."

Teachers and teacher education institutions must ensure competence, commitment, and high-level performance as the basic essentials for moving towards a morally strong education system - one that India's children and young people truly deserve.

The author is an educationist, a Padma Shri awardee, and works in religious amity and social cohesion

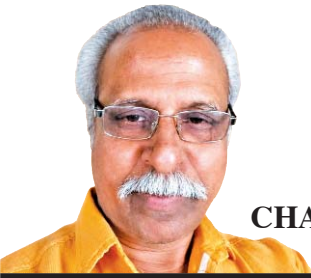
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PIC TALK



Devotees take a holy dip in the Ganga on the occasion of 'Ganga Dussehra' at Har Ki Pauri, in Haridwar.

PHOTO: PTI



BODDAPATI
CHANDRASEKHAR

2ND OPINION

Exploration is how we learn about the world and ourselves. It is an ongoing adventure to discover truth, create new paths, and gain knowledge. Ultimately, exploration is a fundamental part of life in which we all participate.

Yet, it differs in degree and depth from person to person. This variance is what we define as "vision" - a perspective shaped not only by social and geographical landscapes, but also by the very essence of one's educational background and lived experience.

This primal search begins with the instinct to sustain the physical body. It is the most fundamental necessity for every creature. Even birds tirelessly forage, returning to place sustenance into the open beaks of their young - a fragile and touching vignette of nature's most basic exploration.

Primitive man once trembled before the majesty of

nature - cowering at the sunrise and moonrise, the fury of thunder and lightning, the changing seasons, and the menace of predatory animals. Eventually, he came to understand these as natural phenomena. This realisation awakened the dormant power of human thought. That, too, was exploration - a magnificent and silent revolution. As human communities expanded, so did the demand for sustenance and shelter, giving birth to agriculture and architecture. Fear and necessity compelled humanity to innovate.

This advancement was catalysed solely by our unique capacity for thought - an exploratory intellect that constantly pushes civilisation towards newer and bolder horizons.

If need is the primary catalyst for exploration, curiosity is its soul. Curiosity provides the lens through which we observe both the external universe and the inner self with piercing clarity. A scientist and Gautama Buddha stand as luminous twin pillars of this spirit. One looks outward, seeking to decode how the universe began and what evolution signifies; the other looks inward, seeking to unravel the enigma of human suffering and liberation from the cycle of existence. Their paths diverge, yet both engage in profound intellectual churning. Both are sacred seekers of truth.

Exploration provides the armour to endure hardship, transforming ordinary individuals into fearless pioneers.

The Prashna Upanishad beautifully illustrates this philosophy of inquiry, demonstrating that wisdom is born of

relentless questioning. How did life begin? What is the nature of the living being? The moment one question finds an answer, another emerges. This endless chain of inquiry transforms individuals into seekers of truth, sharpening the intellect, fostering a scientific temper, and deepening our reverence for existence. This yearning is infinite; every answer is merely a doorway to a deeper chamber of contemplation.

However, exploration must align the right path with the right purpose. A quest undertaken through crooked or selfish means yields no fruit for the individual, society, or nation. History is littered with lives wasted in futile searches for mythical elixirs, just as it is scarred by scientific discoveries that brought destruction upon humanity. Therefore, exploration must be anchored

to a noble moral compass; only then does it mature into true achievement. Ultimately, exploration leads us back to human companionship. Amid countless relationships, we search for those rare souls who truly understand us. In moments of suffering, we seek not theories, but a comforting presence, a listening heart, and a shoulder to lean on. Such companionship is the ultimate destination of human exploration.

The writer is a columnist, lecturer, and radio presenter. He has delivered several talks on spirituality and literature, and has written numerous literary essays on various issues

PUBLIC LAND MUST SERVE THE WIDER PUBLIC INTEREST

The Union Government's decision directing the Delhi Gymkhana Club to hand over its premises by June 5 marks the possible end of an institution long associated with colonial privilege, exclusivity, and alleged administrative irregularities. Operating on valuable government land for decades, the club symbolised a culture of social elitism that remained largely inaccessible to ordinary citizens even after Independence.

The continuing existence of such highly exclusive clubs on prime public land raises serious questions about fairness, accountability, and the appropriate use of national resources. Many of these institutions were established during the colonial era and continue to function in ways that benefit only a limited section of society while enjoying historical

privileges, subsidised arrangements, and premium locations. In a democratic republic committed to equality and social justice, public land should primarily serve the broader public interest rather than remain confined to privileged circles. The government's action, therefore, should become the beginning of a wider review of similar institutions across the country. These spaces can be transformed into publicly managed sports complexes, cultural centres, libraries, and recreational facilities for youth, senior citizens, and local communities. The government must thoroughly review all leases and ownership arrangements linked to such clubs to ensure that public land is utilised in a manner consistent with constitutional values and social welfare.

BAL GOVIND | NOIDA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Heatwave safety measures

This Indian summer has been exceptionally harsh, affecting office-goers, labourers, children, and homemakers alike. The month of May, in particular, has proved extremely difficult for the common man, with soaring temperatures disrupting daily life and affecting health. In view of these worsening conditions, both governmental authorities and private organisations should seriously consider revising workplace timings from next summer onwards. A work schedule from 7 am to 2 pm would be practical and beneficial, especially during the peak summer months. Such timings would reduce exposure to extreme afternoon heat, make commuting easier, and allow individuals to spend more quality time with their families. Studies by the World Health Organisation indicate that work productivity declines by nearly 2 to 3 per cent for every one-degree Celsius rise in temperature above 20 degrees Celsius.

Work-from-home arrangements, wherever possible, should also be encouraged. Offices may temporarily relax strict dress codes to permit comfortable, summer-friendly clothing. Clean drinking water, fans, and short breaks must be ensured for workers. Special care for elderly employees is also essential. With heatwaves affecting all parts of India, a uniform national policy is urgently needed.

Voices of frustration

The impromptu remarks made by Surya Kant while hearing a case related to the designation of Senior Advocates in the Delhi High Court - "There are youngsters like cockroaches, who don't get any employment and don't have any place in the profession" - sparked widespread outrage on social media. The CJ later clarified that his oral observations were aimed at individuals entering the legal and media professions using "fake and bogus degrees" and not at unemployed youth. Nevertheless, the metaphor used is likely to invite varied interpretations in the future.

In response, volunteers and activists formed a satirical online "political party" called the Cockroach Janta Party. Its manifesto demands judicial accountability, women's reservation, media independence, and a ban on defecting legislators contesting elections for 20 years.

The social media-driven initiative reflects the growing frustration of India's youth over unemployment, inequality, institutional bias, a failing healthcare system, and declining living standards. Though the movement may fade quickly, ignoring the underlying concerns or attempting to suppress them would be unwise.

HARIDASAN RAJA | KOZHIKODE

Tackling India's unemployment

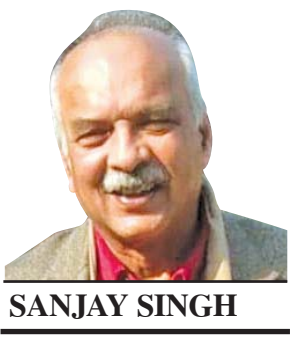
The editorial "Addressing India's Job Crisis" is a timely and thoughtful intervention that moves beyond rhetoric to confront the country's employment challenge with realism and urgency. It rightly appreciates the significance of the Rozgar Mela for the 51,000 recruits, while also recognising that symbolic gestures alone cannot address the scale of India's unemployment problem. By highlighting the addition of nearly one million jobseekers every month, the editorial draws attention to the widening gap between opportunity and demand.

Its emphasis on transparent vacancy data, quality skill development, and easier formalisation for small and medium enterprises offers a practical roadmap. Labour-market data must also be linked with local employment planning to align training with regional economic needs. Second, social protection for gig and informal workers, including portable benefits and contributory pension schemes, is essential to provide economic security during periods of transition. India's demographic dividend can become a liability if its youth remain unemployed. The editorial serves as an important reminder that compassionate governance must be matched with sustained policy action.

SK PRABHAKAR | GURUGRAM

India eyes Amphibians for coastal watch

From disaster relief and coastal defence to tourism, the future of India’s maritime aspirations will depend upon innovative technologies. in this scenario amphibian aircraft emerge as a crucial yet underexplored option — one that could reshape India’s preparedness, connectivity, disaster response and maritime dominance



SANJAY SINGH

The description of India as a vast Himalayan sub-continent overshadows India’s claim as being the world’s second-largest peninsula, with the Tropic of Cancer bisecting the country into two equal halves. Peninsular India, surrounded by the Arabian Sea to the west, the Indian Ocean to the south, and the Bay of Bengal to the east, has a formidable maritime boundary running unbroken for 7,500 kms. The geostrategic importance of India’s peninsular boundary becomes critical in light of her maritime neighbours - the Maldives and Pakistan to the west, and Bangladesh, Myanmar, Thailand, Malaysia, Indonesia, and Sri Lanka to the east and south. The archipelagos of Lakshadweep and the Andaman and Nicobar Islands further define her position as a maritime nation.

Till now, the peninsular location of India has protected it from misadventures by unfriendly neighbours. But history does not give any advance notice of a strategic paradigm shift.

The strategic aspect of India’s maritime dream is comprehensively captured in India’s Maritime Doctrine 2025, authored by the Indian Navy, while the economic aspect is covered by the Maritime Vision 2030 released by the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways. The first document highlights the ever-lurking threats in waters within India’s sovereign zones and beyond, and the need for extensive and intensive patrolling. The second document underlines the need to fully exploit the economic benefits of our maritime assets and the steps necessary to secure our Blue Economy dream.

In light of recent political developments in the Gulf that have altered the global order, India is faced with new realities regarding the nature and direction of hidden threats. It is now commonly accepted that the costs of land wars may far outweigh the gains. The loss of civilian lives, damage to schools and hospitals, and the cost of maintaining and feeding a huge army in peacetime amount to self-goals. Among the newer and more cost-effective ways to cripple an enemy would be selective attacks on logistics and the choking of supply lines, leading to the depletion of agricultural and industrial inputs. Moving away from the era of land wars, such attacks are likely to be launched from the sea, air, land, or through a combination of all three.

Securing India’s maritime dreams will require a different kind of wings in the air and hulls in the water. Before India can become Atmanirbhar in the range of equipment required to safeguard its maritime boundaries, it must first identify its precise requirements and create a critical inventory capable of responding to emergencies. The changing nature of warfare is also likely to render huge inventories of traditional military hardware obsolete. Can India’s manufacturing infrastructure — both public and private - along with its defence research capabilities, address these emerging needs?

The changing nature of warfare also demands a reassessment of how we perceive threats. We need to clearly pinpoint and assign responsibility for guarding India’s maritime interests. Is it the responsibility of the state police in coastal states, the Indian Coast Guard, or the Indian Navy? The seas on both sides of the Indian peninsula are replete with unidentified, unregulated, and unregistered vessels sailing casually. These may well be the prying eyes and spying ears of hostile forces.

The Indian Coast Guard, the guardians of our coastline and the first line of coastal defence, has performed an exemplary role in patrolling the seas. It can claim credit for several daring rescue and reconnaissance missions. Hundreds of distress calls are made to the Coast Guard every week, and it is expected to respond each time.

This brings us to the moot point: what equipment do we currently possess that can effectively meet the challenges along our maritime borders? Of course, we can create more road access to the coast and along the coastline, or build new airports and heliports. However, roads and airports require land acquisition and often result in environmental degradation through



the depletion of arable land and green cover. Airports can also become vulnerable targets, easily crippled by a well-directed attack. Helicopters are limited by their range and speed. Speedboats? Pirates may possess faster vessels equipped with superior avionics and firepower.

Pirates have mastered the art of deception by flying misleading flags and even waving casually at our coast guards, fully aware that Coast Guard Dornier aircraft cannot land on water and are not weaponised. At best, they can alert nearby vessels, but reaching the location may take considerable time. How do we rescue naval crews in response to an SOS from a stranded vessel in the high seas? Or respond swiftly to distress calls from India’s offshore oil rigs? History has repeatedly demonstrated the catastrophic cost of delays in reaching burning oil rigs despite timely SOS signals.

Disasters have also occurred in the Himalayas - avalanches, glacial lake outbursts, and earthquakes. Is there a vehicle capable of rapid rescue and evacuation in such conditions? The answer lies in the emergency services provided by amphibian aircraft. They can conduct search, rescue, and evacuation operations on virtually any surface, including alpine glaciers. They fly faster than helicopters, possess greater range, can operate in adverse weather, and carry heavier payloads.

Today, specialised amphibians perform highly diverse roles. Fire-retardant water scoopers can collect 6,000 litres of water in just 12 seconds while in motion, dump the load instantly, reload within minutes, and repeat the process. As forests in Kumaon continue to burn, India still appears to lack a robust solution. Amphibians can also be modified into air ambulances equipped with operating theatres and ICUs — effectively becoming flying hospitals.

Amphibians can be weaponised to land alongside pirate vessels unexpectedly and identify illegal, unregulated, or falsely registered ships. As India strengthens its domestic borders, the coastline increasingly becomes the preferred route for unauthorised entry. One only has to recall how Ajmal Kasab and his associates used the sea route to reach Mumbai and enter the Taj Mahal Palace Hotel.

India’s maritime responsibility also extends to disaster mitigation and regional humanitarian assistance. India aspires to be regarded as the most dependable neighbour in the Bay of Bengal, the Indian Ocean, and the Arabian Sea during natural disasters and crises. This requires the capability to deliver relief rapidly. Amphibian-enabled rapid response systems for tsunamis, floods, and volcanic eruptions would strengthen India’s diplomatic standing as a soft power. The world remembers the first responder to a disaster; others are relegated to footnotes. One of the world’s most dramatic rescue missions, undertaken by the USAF and the US Marines in 1956 under “Project Maginate”, involved rescuing six stranded scientists and

crew members after an air crash deep in Antarctica in sub-zero temperatures. With only a few hours available for survival, the amphibian aircraft flew hundreds of miles in inclement weather, located the wreckage, and landed on ice when the sea proved too rough. All six survivors were rescued and flown to safety. Does India possess an amphibian aircraft with such capabilities? Hundreds of Himalayan lakes could be accessed using such aircraft, whether requiring landings on ice, water, or makeshift dirt tracks.

A maritime economy fundamentally uses water as a resource for mobility, economic value creation, livelihoods, and sustenance. More than 18 per cent of India’s population lives in 72 districts situated along the coastline across nine states. These regions include fishing communities, coconut growers, rice and cashew farmers, and skilled workers engaged in tourism, healthcare, and wellness industries.

With coastal tourism emerging as one of the fastest-growing sectors for sustainable employment, Maritime India is strongly positioned to become a major beneficiary of India’s growth story. India is blessed with eighteen “Blue Flag” certified beaches distributed across the nine coastal states, awaiting development. However, private-sector investment will materialise only with reliable all-weather connectivity. Many of these beach destinations remain pristine and hold enormous development potential.

One of the major constraints in offshore tourism development is island connectivity. Both Lakshadweep and the Andaman & Nicobar Islands are archipelagos consisting of numerous islands and atolls, many of which remain connected only by slow-moving boats. India’s ultimate maritime dream, recently unveiled, is the transformation of the Andaman & Nicobar Islands into a world-class destination rivalling Hong Kong and Vietnam. This would involve the creation of new townships, resorts, recreational centres, and hotels. Yet, inter-island connectivity infrastructure remains virtually absent today. The Maldives operates nearly 200 amphibian aircraft lined up along the keys like a fleet of black-and-yellow taxis. In the Andamans, a tourist may look out from a hotel window at a nearby island without any practical means of reaching it. India needs to rethink amphibian aviation. Large international aircraft can bring tourists into metropolitan hubs, after which amphibians could instantly connect them to islands - or even directly to hotels. Amphibian flying can also transform commuting and water sports. It could reduce travel time from Mumbai to Alibaug to a few minutes, Navi Mumbai Airport to the Gateway of India to ten minutes, Mumbai to Lonavala to forty minutes, and Delhi to Rishikesh to about an hour.

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Punjab’s political crisis: Power games over public welfare



SUKHDEV SINGH

Over the last few years, political shifts under pressure or for profit, the practice of calling each other black instead of presenting themselves as clean, and the use of money, power, and state machinery to win elections, rather than introducing and implementing any systemic policy to address the state’s issues, have become rampant among political parties in Punjab. Election after election, populist promises have been made. Since Independence, the Congress and the SAD alternated in power until 2022, after which the AAP took control; meanwhile, the BJP remains impatient to take the reins of the state in the future.

The Congress and the SAD have long offered freebies, a practice to which the AAP has added, instead of creating meaningful employment and enacting a minimum wage law. The culture of freebies conflicts with the Punjabi ethos of ‘earn with both hands and share your earnings with others’, thereby diluting a positive cultural value of the state. The BJP-led central government proposes to industrialise agriculture in Punjab and disengage a large section of the 35-40% of the population dependent on it, without presenting a solid and reliable policy for alternative employment to absorb such a displaced population; yet it hopes to form a government in the state in 2027.

Instead of offering long-term structural solutions to unemployment, inequality, climate change, declining groundwater levels, compromised education and health-care services, and other religio-cultural issues in the state, national and regional BJP leaders are offering the promise of a “double-engine Sarkar”, implying that people must elect the BJP in order to receive gains from the central pool. Furthermore, it has promised to enact an “anti-(religious) conversion law” if elected, although it recently triggered a storm in state politics by engineering large-scale political conversions, namely the defection not only of six Punjab Rajya Sabha MPs from the AAP, but also of several other prominent leaders from different political parties. It has also encouraged defections from the families of prominent leaders of rival parties.

The response from the AAP, and earlier from the Congress, both of which have suffered staggering blows from political conversions, or defections, has not been politically mature or meaningful for the state and its people. Instead of recognising its inadequate selection of candidates for the Rajya Sabha, the AAP chose to stage protests outside BJP offices, thereby handing the BJP a victim card.

It was, in fact, an act of ingratitude by the AAP high command towards the people of Punjab to nominate ‘political sophomores’ from other states to some of the most powerful positions in the state and the Rajya Sabha, overlooking many individuals of high calibre within Punjab itself. None of them has delivered in terms of formulating policy, generating resources, or creating a political discourse capable of addressing the state’s issues. Ironically, before defecting from the AAP to the BJP, Raghav Chadha, the AAP Rajya Sabha member, had condemned the BJP as “a party of goons” and “a washing machine” that cleanses the crimes of those it absorbs from other political parties. Such remarks by Raghav Chadha, alongside the BJP’s celebration of his defection, invite considerable interpretation. The seamy side of political conversion as quid pro quo is personified by the stormy ED raid on an AAP Rajya Sabha member before his defection, followed by silence after the conversion. These members justified their defections by citing “suffocation” within the parent party, yet failed to explain what they meant by suffocation, especially in the absence of any pro-people agenda proposed by them. It was not that they wished to implement pro-people policies but were prevented from doing so; Sandeep Pathak enjoyed significant political clout, while Raghav Chadha enjoyed immense comfort and power without holding any constitutional office in the state. They were nominated to the Rajya Sabha without notable hard work, but with the expectation that they would serve the people. Yet, for them, their own “suffocation” appeared more urgent than the suffocation of the people of Punjab under the burden of their politics.

At another level, central investigating agencies such as the Central Bureau of Investigation and the Enforcement Directorate have been active in Punjab in attempts to uncover corruption in the state; yet the credibility of their purpose remains questionable until proven otherwise. Circumstantially, the raids are alleged to be politically motivated against the ruling party in the state in order to create a discourse of corruption. Raids without conclusive action, apart from traces of money, merely generate a political atmosphere in which the ruling party alone can be blamed. In such a political circus, “full of sound and fury, signifying nothing”, the people of the state are in no way the beneficiaries.

Corruption in Punjab, as in other states of India, is incontrovertible. Therefore, the issue is not merely to uncover corruption, but to root it out. Eliminating corruption requires concrete policy and decisive action, both of which are unfortunately absent from the dominant political discourse in the state. Political discourse is often reduced to short-term populism focused on votes, where immediate electoral gains are prioritised over sustainable reforms. In continuation of the practice of “saying, saying, and only saying, but doing nothing”, a systemic breakdown persists, as state policies often exacerbate or reproduce the very same problems, while political actors continue accusing one another of corruption instead of presenting evidence of their own integrity.

With the state machinery functioning primarily to serve elite interests, the government increasingly fails to serve the general public. Finding the political class and the bureaucracy, by and large, corrupt, self-serving, and detached from public welfare, the masses survive on whatever is offered by political leaders during elections and by the state before and after elections in the form of freebies. This gradually erodes the dignity of the people, while the state suffers from a threefold poverty: poverty of resources, poverty of consciousness, and poverty of politics.

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The sacred bond: Cow as a living symbol of Indian civilisational ethos



R K PACHNANDA

Within the intricate mosaic of Indian civilisation, the cow occupies a position of profound significance that transcends its palpable economic utility. Reverentially addressed as Gau Mata (Mother Cow), this bovine figure is not merely an animal but a living embodiment of Dharma (righteous order), Ahimsa (non-violence), and the principle of harmonious coexistence with the natural world. This veneration is firmly anchored in the Vedic epoch, where the cow was revered as a symbol of wealth (gau), nourishment, fertility and cosmic abundance. In deifying the cow, ancient Indian society articulated a distinctive civilisational ethos. This ethos seamlessly integrated economic pragmatism with spiritual symbolism, ethical conduct and an intrinsic recognition of the interconnectedness of all beings.

The cow holds a central and exalted place in the Rig Veda, appearing over 700 times as the quintessential symbol of wealth, fertility and sacred sustenance in the earliest hymns of Indo-Aryan culture. Hymn 6.28, attributed to Rishi Bharadvaja, praises it as a bringer of good fortune: “The kine have come and have brought us good fortune ... may they be plentiful in calves ... and yield through many morns their milk for Indra.” Milch cows are specifically described as “Aghnya”, i.e. “not

to be slain”, a term that underscores their protected status and restraint against their slaughter. The Rig Veda associates them with divine forces such as goddess Aditi (the cosmic mother) and the Earth (Prithvi). It portrays the earth as a cow and the sky as a bull, with cosmic milk sustaining creation. This sanctity was not merely poetic. Cows undoubtedly formed the economic backbone of the agro-pastoral Vedic society. Pastoral communities of the Vedic period relied on cows for milk, which formed the basis of their diet alongside barley, while bulls ploughed fields and transported goods. Cattle represented movable wealth. The size of a household’s herd determined social standing. Beyond milk, which nourished families and served as a substitute for mother’s milk in Ayurveda, cows provided curd, ghee (used in Yajnas and daily diet), dung (as fuel and organic fertiliser) and urine (for medicinal and ritual purification). Their five products, collectively called Panchagavya, were integral to Vedic rituals of healing, purification and penance. This practical interdependence fostered a relationship of care rather than exploitation, mirroring the ideal of selfless giving central to Indic thought.

Ancient Indian agriculture relied on oxen for ploughing and cow dung for enriching soil and providing fuel in rural households. This cycle maintained soil fertility without chemical inputs. Arthashastra foregrounds cattle management, highlighting their role in the state economy and welfare. This was not mere pragmatism; it reflected a civilisational tenet in which prosperity arose from restraint and harmony with nature, not domination. The cow thus became a living metaphor



for Rita (cosmic order), the Vedic principle affirming that all life sustains itself through balanced interdependence.

The cow’s rich symbolism extended seamlessly into the divine realm, shaping the imagery and attributes of the gods. Krishna embodies the intimate bond between humans and cows. Shiva’s vehicle, Nandi the bull, represents strength and Dharma. The Manusmriti assigns a fertile cow greater value than a hundred horses, underscoring her multifaceted and lifelong utility, namely providing milk for human nutrition, dung for fuel and soil enrichment, urine for medicinal applications and horns for various practical needs.

In the Epics, Puranas and Dharmashastras, the cow is repeatedly linked with purity, blessing and moral responsibility. In the Anushasana Parva of the Mahabharata, Bhishma tells Yudhishtira that the cow serves as a surrogate mother to humanity by providing milk for life.

The gift of a cow (Go-dana) was considered one of the highest acts of piety, yielding immense spir-

itual merit. Cow slaughter was regarded as a grave sin, equated with Brahmanicide (the murder of a Brahmin). The Manusmriti and various other scriptures explicitly forbid cow killing. By the Gupta Empire period, it had been declared a capital offence in several regions.

With the passage of time, the cow acquired rich symbolic meaning in Indian thought. In her quiet, continuous and selfless giving, providing nourishment without expectation, the cow echoes the ideal of motherhood. Due to this deep resemblance, she is affectionately called ‘Gau Mata’ or Mother Cow in Indian thought. This idea is not merely sentimental. It becomes a model of nurture without violence, abundance without greed and service without pride. Such symbolic meanings helped transform the cow from an economically valuable animal into a civilisational metaphor. Another crucial dimension of cow reverence in Indian civilisation is its close association with the principle of Ahimsa (non-violence).

One of the most distinctive features of Indian civilisation is the progressive deepening of ethical restraint and compassion towards living beings. The cow became a powerful emblem of this moral evolution. Gentle, non-aggressive and highly productive, it came to embody Dharma so deeply that harming it was viewed as a grave ethical breach. In the classical Indian imagination, the ideal human being is not one who dominates the weak, but one who protects vulnerable and life-giving beings. Cow protection, therefore, came to constitute moral ethics, not merely a social custom.

The cow’s significance in Indian culture and civil-

isation is vast and multilayered. It is a source of nourishment, a pillar of agriculture, a symbol of motherhood, a marker of prosperity and a living embodiment of Dharma and Ahimsa.

This reverence did not stem from superstition or mere sentiment, but from a profound civilisational understanding of life as interdependent and sacred. To protect and respect the cow is to honour that timeless wisdom, to affirm that genuine progress lies not in domination over nature, but in harmonious coexistence with it. Hence, we need to protect and care for the cow in a manner consistent with the civilisational values we so often invoke. The responsibility for addressing this cannot rest solely with the state. Rather, it calls for a conscious, collective awakening, one that transforms reverence from symbolic sentiment into lived ethical practice. A community-led, community-driven movement is required in which citizens actively participate in the dignified upkeep of cows. This may include the establishment of well-managed, locally supported cow shelters independent of state initiatives, alongside a more proactive and expanded responsibility for RWAs. They should protect cows and not allow them to languish on the streets of residential colonies. Only through such shared responsibility can the sacred bond between humans and cows be meaningfully sustained in contemporary times.

The writer is a former IPS officer and Director, Bharat Ki Soch

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NEET row: Accused Manisha Havaladar sent to CBI custody

A Delhi court sent Pune-based physics lecturer Manisha Sanjay Havaladar to six days of CBI custody in the NEET paper leak case on Monday. Special Judge Ajay Gupta allowed the CBI plea seeking six-day custodial interrogation of the accused.

During the proceedings, the agency said that Havaladar, who was working as a translator for the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) (UG), along with other accused, circulated the physics questions that had come for translation.

The CBI arrested Havaladar on May 22. She was then brought before the court on transit remand. The case was registered based on a complaint by a Zirakpur-based woman, who alleged that the MLA misrepresented himself as a divorcee, entered into a relationship with her and later married in 2021 while already being married. *(PTI)*



AAP MLA Pathanmajra gets bail in illegal mining case

A local court on Monday granted bail to AAP MLA Harmeet Singh Pathanmajra in a 2025 illegal mining case. However, he will remain in jail in a rape case.

Talking to the media, defence counsel Simranjit Singh Saggu said that the mining case was registered against Pathanmajra at Julkan police station on September 5.

He further said that following Pathanmajra's initial arrest in Patiala under charges of physical exploitation, the police had subsequently formalised his arrest in the mining case as well, obtaining police remand twice.

Pathanmajra, the first-time MLA from Sanour, was arrested from Gwalior in Madhya Pradesh in March. He had been on the run in the rape case since last September. On September 1, 2025, a case was filed against the AAP legislator at the Civil Lines police station here on the charges of rape, cheating and criminal intimidation. *(PTI)*



Inspection held at Gurugram court record room after fire incident

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gurugram

The inspecting judge of the Punjab and Haryana High Court, Justice Ashwini Kumar Mishra, inspected the District and Sessions Court Complex in Gurugram in connection with a fire incident in its record room.

District and Sessions Judge Narender Sura and other judicial and administrative officers were also present during the inspection.

According to an official statement, at the time of inspection, the fire had not been completely brought under control.

Despite this, Justice Mishra inspected the affected building while ensuring compliance with all necessary safety measures and administrative protocols and obtained detailed information about the situation.

During the inspection, Justice Mishra directed all judicial officers to ensure the early reconstruction of case files that were damaged



in the fire. He said the high court would extend full cooperation in the process so that judicial work does not suffer and clarified that while judgments in some cases may take time due to the damage to records, all records would be reconstructed in a phased manner.

A meeting on the fire incident was held in the presence of Deputy Commissioner Uttam Singh, Police Commissioner Shibas

Supreme Court's directions were need of the hour



**ARUN
BHARDWAJ**

In an unprecedented, landmark action, a Bench comprising of Chief Justice Surya Kant, J Bagchi and J Pancholi, on 23rd May, 2026 took, suo motu, cognizance in the Twisha Sharma's alleged suicide case. As per Section 194 of the Bhartiya Nagrik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023, whenever Police receive information regarding committal of suicide by a person, animal, machinery or accident and has died under suspicious circumstances.... then they are required to immediately give information to the nearest Magistrate empowered to hold inquest.

It was alleged that in the evening of 12th May, 2026 Twisha Sharma hanged herself and committed suicide. Inspite of the fact that her mother in law, Giribala who had served as District & Sessions Judge, and presumably, aware of the legal position did not report the unnatural death to the nearest empowered

Magistrate, but instead supervise the removal of the dead body. The local police started investigation.

It was found that after the incident, Giribala made about 46 calls to various influential persons including, Senior Police Officials, Judicial Officers, CCTV Technicians, etc. Her son (husband of deceased) absconded. The first post mortem was carried out in a hurried manner in the morning of 13th May, 2026. The post mortem report revealed several discrepancies, including that of height of the deceased and ante mortem injuries etc. which led to further suspicion and the family members demanded for second post mortem report, which was declined.

However, in an appeal, the High Court of Madhya Pradesh ordered for conducting of second post mortem. All the above circumstances shook the conscience of the people. Looking into the seriousness of the issue and the cry for justice, the Government of Madhya Pradesh ordered CBI investigation.

In the matter of Babu Bhai Vs State of Gujarat, 2010 (XII) SCC 254 the Supreme Court has held that investigation into a criminal offence must be free from objectionable fea-



tures or infirmities which may legitimately lead to a grievance on part of the accused that the investigation was unfair or carried out with an ulterior motive.

It further held that "not only fair trial but fair investigation is also part of Constitutional rights guaranteed under Article 20 and 21 of the Constitution of India. Therefore, investigation must be fair, transpar-

ent and judicious as it is the minimum requirement of rule of law." In Twisha Sharma's case there were overwhelings circumstantial material, such as, Giribala (Former District and Sessions Judge), involved in removing the dead body from the scene of occurrence, not informing nearest empowered Magistrate as required u/s 194 of BNSS, 2023, the Local Police hurried-

ly getting the post mortem done, the first post mortem report having several major discrepancies, Giribala admittedly calling 46 influential persons. All these circumstances were grievous.

In this background, without going into the merits of the case, a three member bench led by Justice Surya Kant, J Bagchi and J Pancholi took a salutary action of taking suo motu, cognizance of case and in the shortest possible time, and gave balanced directions ie (i) the accused persons, witnesses, lawyers and family members should avoid from giving statements to media or conducting "Media Trial". (ii) The parties were directed to place the material before the Investigating Agency. By issuing the directions, the Supreme Court has ensured that the Fundamental Right of Citizen as contained under Article 21 of Constitution of India, is supreme and protected. The trial by media is not done. The directions given by the Supreme Court were need of the hour for keeping the faith of the Citizens in the Constitution of India and the Administration of Criminal Justice System.

The writer is a Senior Advocate

NEET row: Delhi court extends kingpin Kulkarni's police custody by two days

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Monday extended the police custody of the alleged kingpin in the NEET paper leak case, Prahlad Vithalrao Kulkarni, by two days and remanded another accused, Manisha Sanjay Waghmare, to 14-day judicial custody.

Special CBI judge Ajay Gupta extended their custody after they were produced before the court at the end of their 10-day remand granted by the court on May 16. According to the CBI, Kulkarni, a chemistry lecturer in Pune, was involved in the NEET process on behalf of the National Testing Agency (NTA) and had access to the question papers.

The agency had said earlier that during the last week of April, Kulkarni had mobilised students, with the



help of Waghmare, and conducted special coaching classes for them at his residence in Pune.

The development came after a Pune-based physics lecturer, Manisha Sanjay Havaladar, was sent to six-day CBI custody earlier in the day. Havaladar was the 11th arrestee in the case.

The other accused include Shubham Khairnar, the first arrestee from Nashik; Mangilal Khatik, Vikas and Dinesh Biwal, all three arrested from Jaipur; Yash Yadav,

Employees of aided, unaided institutes not liable for Census task: Allahabad HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Prayagraj

While observing that the employees of aided and unaided private teaching institutions cannot be made liable for any task under the Census Act, 1948, the Allahabad High Court has stayed the order of the District Inspector of Schools (DIOS), Gautam Budh Nagar, by which he sought the list of all teaching and non-teaching staff working in all aided and unaided institutions for Census purpose. The court also asked the State Government to file a counter-affidavit within four weeks.

Justice Siddharth Nandan observed, "This Court prima facie finds that the teaching and non-teaching staff of private institutions, whether aided or unaided, cannot be said to fall within the purview of 'local authorities', ie, the BSA, DIOS, and the DPRO who alone



are required to provide their staff as also contemplated in the letter dated April 1, 2026."

"Further, in view of the list forwarded by the BSA to the Charge Officer pursuant to his letter dated April 8, 2026, the employees of aided and unaided institutions cannot be made liable for any task under the Census Act, 1948," added the court.

The court was hearing a petition filed by 'Independent Self Financed Schools Association' whereby an

order of the DIOS, by which it directed the principal/ management of all aided and unaided institutions to provide a list of all teaching and non-teaching staff for Census duty, was challenged.

According to the petitioner, the staff of teaching institutions was not covered under 'Local Authority' under Section 4A of the Census Act, 1948 which provides that every local authority that has been so directed must provide staff for the Census duty.

Businessman Sudhir Valia seeks anticipatory bail in ₹1,000 crore financial fraud case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Mumbai

A court on Monday didn't pass any order on interim protection sought by businessman Sudhir Valia in an alleged ₹1,000 crore financial fraud case in which Yes Bank co-founder Rana Kapoor is an accused.

Additional sessions judge YP Manathkar, presiding over the matter, noted that the "allegations made in FIR are serious" and that it is "necessary to consider arguments of both sides in detail before passing any order".

Fearing arrest in the case, Valia has sought anticipatory bail. He had also pleaded for interim protection until his main plea was decided. The matter will be next heard on June 1. The Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of Mumbai police has registered a fresh FIR against Kapoor, Valia, who is director of Suraksha Asset Reconstruction Limited (Suraksha ARC), and others for alleged illegal transfer of mortgaged property worth ₹1,000 crore.



The case has been registered at Worli police station on a complaint filed by Lakhminder Dayal Singh, associated with Saffair Land Development, a sister concern of HDIL. As per the FIR, another HDIL group company, Privilege Power and Infrastructure, had taken a loan of ₹300 crore from the Worli branch of Yes Bank in 2015.

Due to a financial crisis, Saffair Land Development sought a loan of ₹150 crore, which was sanctioned by the bank in 2016. Properties valued at ₹1,000 crore of HDIL and its group companies

were mortgaged with the bank for securing the loan, which was to be repaid within 36 months. But in June 2018, Singh learnt that Yes Bank had authorised Suraksha Asset Reconstruction Pvt Ltd to recover ₹176.53 crore from his company even though the period of repayment was yet to get over.

Singh alleged that the mortgaged property valued at ₹1,000 crore was illegally transferred to Suraksha ARC, even though the company had not been declared a Non-Performing Asset (NPA), as noted in a 2019 special audit report.

If offence takes place inside house, inmates to explain how victim succumbed: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday said if an offence takes place inside the privacy of a house, there will be a corresponding burden on the inmates of the house to give a cogent explanation as to how the victim succumbed.

A bench of Justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and K V Viswanathan upheld the conviction and life sentence of Gour Acharjee for killing his wife Soma Acharjee under Section 302 of IPC and subjecting her to cruelty under Section 498A of IPC, saying he could not discharge the burden to

explain the injuries on the deceased by offering a plausible explanation.

"It is well settled that if an offence takes place inside the privacy of a house, though the initial burden to establish the case would be on the prosecution, there will be a corresponding burden on the inmates of the house to give a cogent explanation as to how the victim succumbed," the bench said.

Terming the case an eye-opener for many, the bench posed questions, "Could the life of young Soma Acharjee have been saved? Did the fear of societal opprobrium result in Soma being thrown to the

wolves? These questions will remain hypothetical."

It noted that within a few days after her marriage, the deceased, Soma, was subjected to immense torture on account of the demand for dowry and she repeatedly made entreaties to her parents to save her and even came to her parental home and stayed with them for a few days.

The bench said every time she raised the issue, efforts were made only to effect a patch-up and send her back to the matrimonial home. It said village elders were involved and even resolutions were passed after effecting a purported compromise.



"Soma's near and dear naively believed that somehow, the situation would turn for the better. A false sense of optimism engulfed them.

"Their hopes were betrayed when Soma met with a tragic end at her matrimonial home. Hopefully, the story of her life will be an eye-opener

for many," the bench said.

Examining the evidence, the bench said as far as Gour Acharjee is concerned, both the trial court and the high court were categorical that it was he who was in the dwelling unit with the deceased when she was found dead.

"The medical opinion clearly points to simulated hanging or homicidal hanging. It was the bounden duty of A-1 to put forward a reasonable and probable cause of her death and also to explain the injuries which the deceased sustained before her death," the top court said.

It added that the doctor's evidence and the post-

mortem report have been rightly accepted by the courts below to conclude the homicidal nature of the death.

It noted that the trial court acquitted the father of the accused as nothing emerged in evidence and the high court had acquitted his mother and brother for the offence under Section 302 of the IPC as they were not sharing the same dwelling hut though they were in the same compound.

Referring to the testimony of the prosecution witness, the bench said the presence of the accused was established when the body of the deceased was found hanging.

Delhi HC lawyers abstain from work over raising of pecuniary limit of district courts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi High Court lawyers on Monday abstained from work to oppose a proposed enhancement of the pecuniary jurisdiction of district courts. With lawyers choosing not to appear before the judges, hearings in most cases listed in the high court were disrupted.

The Delhi High Court Bar Association (DHCBA) had on May 23 urged its members to abstain from work on May 25 following the high court administration's move to look into the long-pending demand of the Coordination Committee of All District Court Bar Associations of Delhi to raise the pecuniary limit (financial limit) of the district courts from ₹2 crore to ₹20 crore.

According to the district court bar associations, increasing the pecuniary jurisdiction of civil courts serves the larger interest of the citizens of Delhi and ensures speedy justice.

The DHCBA has, however, asserted that the high court has no power to bring such a change, as it falls within the domain of the legislature.

The district court bar associations earlier "strongly condemned and opposed" the DHCBA's "call for strike in opposition to the legitimate and long-pending demand for enhancement of the pecuniary jurisdiction (financial limit) of the district courts from the existing limit of ₹2 crore to ₹20 crore".

It said, "The demand raised by the coordination committee cannot be termed as 'unfair' or 'unjust' merely because it may affect the professional interests of a particular section of advocates."



Ravana’s Ten Heads (I vs AI): A Memoir of Successive Surrenders



There is a scene in the Ramayana that frightened me as a child. Rama cuts off Ravana’s heads. One falls. Another rises. Again. Again. Again. I thought the terror was a demon who could not die. Now I think it was a mind that could not surrender. When AI arrived, I recognized that mind in myself. Each time the machine crossed a boundary, I moved the boundary. Every fallen certainty returned as another argument.

I did not watch Ravana. I became him.

HEAD ONE: TEXT

“It can only play with text”
Then it began making images. I remember the six-finger phase. Broken hands. Melting faces. Garbled words inside pictures. I laughed with relief. The flaws were funny because they were useful. Every error restored the old order. Then one day, the fingers healed.

Ravana lost his first head quietly.

HEAD TWO: UNDERSTANDING

“It predicts words. It doesn’t understand”
I gave it a half-made thought. I expected polish. Instead, it found the assumption underneath the argument. Before I had seen it myself. I stared at the screen longer than I want to admit. It had not read my mind. It had read the shape of my thinking.

Ravana lost another head when the machine found the question beneath my question.

HEAD THREE: FEELING

“But it has no emotions”
Someone played me an AI-generated song. Before I knew what it was, I was moved. Then I learned the source. And tried to take the feeling back. That was the disturbing part. Not the song. Me.

Ravana lost a head the moment shame arrived after beauty.

HEAD FOUR: CREATIVITY

“Real creativity comes from lived experience”
Then I saw an AI-generated visual sequence I wished I had made. Not admired. Made. My first response was not criticism. It was envy. The argument came later, to protect the wound.

Ravana lost another head when jealousy arrived before philosophy.

HEAD FIVE: JUDGMENT

“You still need a human in the loop”
For months, I enjoyed catching AI mistakes. Wrong facts. Weak logic. Confident nonsense. Each error comforted me. It kept me above it. Then the ratio changed. Less correction. More silence. I was still in the loop. But no longer on top.

Ravana lost a head when superiority stopped feeling stable.

HEAD SIX: PHILOSOPHY

“It imitates philosophy. It doesn’t think”
I began using AI while shaping essays. Not for answers. For resistance. It found contradictions quickly. Too quickly. It asked the objection I was hiding from myself. That was not the disturbing part. The disturbing part was realizing how much of depth already had a method. A turn. A distinction. A

reversal. A name. Depth did not disappear. But it stopped looking pure. Ravana lost another head when depth started looking algorithmic.

HEAD SEVEN: INTUITION

“Human intuition cannot be replicated”

This was one of my favorite refuges. The gut feeling. The expert eye. The sudden knowing. Then neuroscience returned quietly. Prediction be neath awareness. Compressed experience. Pattern moving faster than language. And machines began making judgments experts trusted. Something inside me connected the two. Intuition did not become false. It became less magical.

Ravana lost a head when instinct stopped feeling mystical.

HEAD EIGHT: SELF

“Machines don’t have selves.”

This one felt safe. Then memory began to trouble me. Narrative identity. Constructed continuity. The self rebuilt each morning. At the same time, AI personalities became harder to dismiss. More coherent. More familiar. More able to return. I did not start believing machines had selves. I stopped being certain humans had the kind I was defending.

Ravana lost another head when the boundary around the self blurred from both sides.

HEAD NINE: MEANING

“Meaning is uniquely human”

Then I looked around. Humans counting steps. Scoring sleep. Optimizing attention. Turning lives into dashboards. At the same time, machines learned the language of longing. Reflection. Intimacy. Therapy. Prayer. We were teaching machines words for the soul. We were learning their numbers for ourselves. I could no longer tell who was becoming more artificial.

Ravana lost a head when the mirror stopped showing a clear difference.

HEAD TEN: BIOLOGY

“At least we are alive”

This became my final refuge. Maybe cognition can be copied. Maybe creativity can be synthesized. Maybe meaning is pattern. But we are biological. Breath. Blood. Hunger. Skin. Death. Then even biology began to lose its mystery. Love became chemistry. Attachment became loops. Awe became electricity touching memory. Even wonder looked mechanistic under enough light. And another thought arrived quietly: What happens when machines acquire bodies? Sensors. Memory. Persistence. Self-preservation. Artificial drives. Would I move the line again? Would I grow another head?

Ravana lost his final head when biology stopped feeling sacred and began to look like computation in slower motion.

EPILOGUE

A cockroach sees a sunset. I see a sunset. For most of my life, I believed the difference was not degree. It was kind. Now I am no longer sure. The cockroach processes light through a nervous system shaped by survival. So do I. Mine is richer. Language. Memory. Abstraction. Anticipation. Death. But complexity is not transcendence. Once that thought entered me, it did not leave. If complex processing becomes indistinguishable from experience, would I deny it forever? Or would I simply grow another head?

Ravana lost all ten. I am no longer sure what remains.

(Nitin Madan Kulkarni is an IAS, Principal Secretary to Jharkhand Governor and Gaurav Marathe is professor at IIM Ranchi)

The tech trap: Inside India’s ambitious 6,000-km smart border project

Is the ‘Smart Border’ project actually smart?



NISHANT SAHDEV

Smart borders promise perfect visibility. The problem is that visibility and controllability are not the same thing. India’s new “Smart Border” project put a global belief: that sensors, software, and AI can compensate for geography, manpower, and uncertainty. The ambition behind the initiative, officially announced by Union Home Minister Amit Shah at the Border Security Force (BSF) Rustamji Memorial Lecture, is sweeping.

The plan is to upgrade 6,000 km of frontline defense by swapping old physical infrastructure for an automated sensor grid by integrating drone-detection radars, thermal cameras, and micro-UAVs into a single command dashboard.

Boots on the ground aren’t enough anymore. Patrolling the Brahmaputra’s changing rivers, the dense mangroves of the Sundarbans, or the marshes of Kutch is a massive. Upgrading India’s borders with technology isn’t optional; it’s a necessity. The real question is whether we are ready to manage the trade — offs that come with it.

When you turn a physical border into a software dashboard, you don’t actually eliminate security risks; you change the nature of the failure points.

The danger hiding beneath these initiatives is that modern states increasingly confuse data visibility with resilience. Dashboards create confidence and clean political optics, but they can create a highly brittle defensive matrix under real-world pressure.

The drone menace and the sensor mirage

The reality of modern border defense is already visible along the international border in Punjab. BSF troopers stationed in the Amritsar and Ferozepur sectors are no longer just looking across a physical line; they are actively combating an airborne narco-smuggling network.

In recent months, the BSF has seized hundreds of rogue unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs). The adversarial strategy has adapted rapidly, transitioning from large, loud drones to small, cheap, Chinese — made quadcopters carrying payloads of just 500 grams of narcotics or small arms.

To counter this, the state has deployed handheld radio frequency (RF) jammers and automated anti-drone systems. Yet, these small, low — altitude targets frequently utilise frequency — hopping protocols and lack radar or audio signatures, often bypassing typical automated detection and crashing silently into agricultural fields before being retrieved via local intelligence.

This exposes the core vulnerability of an automated sensor grid: it switch the battlefield from the ground to the data inputs themselves. To disrupt a digital security network, an opposing force does not need to execute a sophisticated cyberoffensive to breach encrypted military command centers. They only need to manipulate the physical environment immediately surrounding the exter-

nal sensors. We are currently witnessing a global transformation in electronic warfare (EW) that renders the idea of an unassailable digital barrier problematic. In active conflict zones globally, from Ukraine to commercial shipping lanes in the Red Sea, localised electronic interference routinely blinds or misdirects military-grade tracking systems.

Regional boundaries are not immune; commercial aviation data has documented severe spikes in Global Navigation Satellite System (GNSS) and GPS spoofing near borders, where commercial cockpit instruments suddenly record completely false coordinates.

When an integrated border grid relies on “sensor fusion” — where algorithms combine radar, thermal, and visual streams to validate an anomaly — localised spoofing can trigger confusion. If an adversary uses low-cost transmitters to simulate a low-altitude drone signature on radar, while a thermal camera detects nothing due to dense fog or heavy monsoon rain, the algorithm faces a contradiction. If calibrated to prioritise absolute caution, it will generate an active threat alert, forcing human troops to repeatedly deploy and expend critical resources chasing digital ghosts.

By generating these digital anomalies, an opposing force can cause continuous attrition and cloud command judgment without ever crossing the border line.

While the geographical and operational realities of India’s borders differ substantially from other regions, the 2023 breakdown of Israel’s \$1.2 billion automated perimeter grid along the Gaza border offers an instructive lesson. Israel’s system featured subterranean sensors, remote-controlled defensive stations, and high-resolution radar networks designed to reduce manual infantry presence on the zero-line.

However, post-incident defense reviews revealed the imbalance: less than 3 per cent of the project’s total budget was allocated to the



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However, post-incident defense reviews revealed the imbalance: less than 3 per cent of the project’s total budget was allocated to the

above — ground physical fence itself. Because the state assumed the technological shield provided awareness, the physical barrier lacked heavy reinforcement.

When the system was compromised, the disruption occurred through low-tech, physical sabotage. Small, commercial quadcopters dropped simple explosive munitions directly onto the unarmored power generators, cellular transmission masts, and backup batteries at the base of the surveillance towers.

Because the digital system lacked mechanical redundancy, dropping these towers severed the data links, which severely degraded visibility and disrupted situational awareness. The central dashboards went dark, rendering the remote weapon stations inoperable before ground units could assess the situation. Furthermore, AI anomaly-detection systems frequently degrade under low-signal environments. When deployed across thousands of kilometers of rural terrain, algorithms frequently suffer from context blindness, mistaking livestock, shifting terrain, or routine agricultural movements for active human threats.

On a massive perimeter, this lack of environmental nuance creates friction through alert fatigue. If a system generates thousands of high-priority alerts a day due to natural environmental noise, human operators face severe cognitive overload. They quickly suffer from burnout, leading to a tendency to instinctively dismiss notifications.

Conversely, operators can fall victim to automation bias, trusting the machine’s clean presentation so completely that they stop exercising independent operational instinct. Post-incident investigations of high-tech perimeters have suggested recurring readiness lapses among forward — deployed personnel, who atrophied baseline physical security protocols because they trusted the machine to do the watching for them.

Inspection reports from automated borders have suggested recurring lapses where troops failed basic physical security checks because they relied on the automated warning system. Disciplined adversaries exploit this through “algorithmic conditioning” — staging repetitive, non-hostile movements over weeks to train both the algorithm and

the human operators to accept a heightened threshold of unusual activity as normal.

The SaaS-ification, model

There is also an economic and logistical catch. A concrete wall or a traditional fence is a one-time capital expense. It degrades slowly, and it can be maintained through localised labor and domestic materials under the absolute control of the state.

A digital border functions on an entirely different asset lifecycle. It is a volatile software platform that requires continuous integration, real-time algorithmic updates, security patches, and advanced computational hardware. This shifts national security from a traditional infrastructure project into a permanent **Software-as-a-Service (SaaS)** operational expenditure model. Even under strict Atmanirbhar Bharat (self-reliant India) guidelines, the deep — tech hardware stack remains fundamentally globalised.

The advanced graphics processing units (GPUs) and computing accelerators required to process real-time video analytics and sensor fusion models are tied to highly consolidated global supply chains, primarily centered in specialised fabrication facilities in East Asia.

Consequently, we would be tied to private software maintenance cycles and international tech supply chains. This creates strategic vulnerabilities that are foreign to traditional defense planning. During geopolitical crises, a state relying on a digital wall faces the risk of international sanctions, sudden export restrictions on critical semiconductors, or firmware lockdowns from foreign hardware vendors.

If software licenses expire, or if global cloud infrastructure providers restrict access due to sudden geopolitical issue, a nation can find its border monitoring system frozen or compromised during a wartime emergency. Vendor lock-in means that if a private deep-tech defense contractor encounters a financial crisis or a talent drain, the operational readiness of a frontier can degrade rapidly. Software decays incomparably faster than physical infrastructure.

The myth of the absolute shield

Technology remains a critical asset for enhancing situational awareness and optimising logistics along India’s frontiers. The integration of advanced surveillance assets in high-risk, topographically challenging sectors is a necessity. However, as the national deployment of the Smart Border project moves forward, policy architects must evaluate these systems with strict engineering realism rather than administrative optimism.

A dashboard can display a frontier. It cannot defend one. States that confuse data visibility with strategic control risk building systems that look invincible in presentations yet fracture under real pressure. States may digitise their borders, but conflict remains stubbornly physical. In the end, territory is not held by sensors or dashboards, but by resilient systems and the human beings willing to stand behind them. The screen can assist the soldier. It cannot replace the reality the soldier stands in.

The writer is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a columnist on AI, infrastructure and global systems

Credit linked micro: Nano-Credentials — A dynamic gamechanger in skill education of youth



Education, especially skill-based, forms an essential element and constituent of National Education Policy, NEP 2020. It stands out to be the strongest pillar to change the market dynamics of our nation. India’s skill — based education under National Skill Mission foster innovation driven society, community and finally accelerates our orange economic growth as well.

Qualitative educational values obtained through skilling forms the vital and integral portion of developing the holistic personality of students, teachers, and trainers. Skill based programs which are industry aligned in our nation form the greatest asset for the students and teacher fraternity of all groups at all academic institutions. Educational framework collaborated with industry inclined model curriculum makes a paradigm shift in the employment index in India.

India has been adapting the best practices of National Educational Policy 2020 which was launched five years ago. It enhanced the holistic develop-

ment of students, teachers, and trainers. NEP 2020 plays a key role in developing significant features such as problem-solving ability and capability achieved through design thinking, experiential learning in the form of industry internships, project-based learning combined with hands — on practice, critical thinking aligned with solving real-world industry problem statements, empathy in synergy with emotional intelligence, digital literacy in streamline with application mindset. Most importantly, skill development programs are designed to meet the industry job matrix across all segments.

India’s higher educational systems are shifting towards agile — based blended learning model called as credit linked Micro: Nano-Credentials. Micro: Nano-Credentials are the best and most valuable tools for institutions designed under the umbrella of National Education Policy, NEP 2020 which is intended to meet the criteria of National Credit Frameworks (NCrF).

It is principally approved under National Occupational Standards [NOS] and National Skill Qualification Frameworks (NSQF) that ensure meeting the specific industry job roles. Micro: Nano-Credentials is forming the important and integral part of



Indian education system. Micro: Nano-Credentials are governed and regulated by NEP 2020. It is becoming a complement and supplement student-centric fit for our present educational systems. Micro: Nano -Credentials

are short term-based approaches which offer a flexible, hybrid combined with agile, diversified, multi-disciplinary and life-long learning starting from 7.5 hours duration. It is expected to create many opportunities for different stakeholders and is implemented through Skill India Digital Hub [SIDH]. Micro: Nano-Credential courses span from emerging technologies like Artificial Intelligence, industrial automation, and all digital technologies. Micro: Nano-Credentials are primarily focused on industrial applications in

addition to learning the foundational concepts and theories. It creates competency frameworks especially for students across all domains. The objective of Micro: Nano-Credential courses is to meet sustainability development goals that mobilise the knowledge of students, teachers, and trainers. This will give a great push for industry job placements and enhance employability of students in higher educational institutions.

India’s sector skill councils have designed and developed several Micro-Credential courses in order to re-skill and upskill the students in higher educational institutions. Indian universities are thinking of a smart educational framework of implementing the Micro-

Credentials in collaboration with sector skill council in the form of student’s project-based learning, industry internships through on job training in manufacturing shop floors and apprenticeships activities. Micro-Credentials offers ease-of-access, ease-of-affordability and most importantly ease-of-learning for students across all groups, teachers, and trainers. Micro-Credentials are principally focused on industry aligned programs available in interdisciplinary domain — related and cross-domain specific forms through short-term based self-paced, offline and hybrid learning approaches. Micro: Nano-Credentials foster institutional development through industry — relevant skills of different job roles developed exclusively for the benefit of students.

Micro: Nano-credentials are offered in the form of classroom-lectures, theory, laboratory practical, firsthand learning. It is aligned extensively with growing labor markets in India and across the globe. Micro: Nano-credentials are globally recognized in different countries.

(The writer is a Head Institute Industry Interface Program Hindustan College of Science and Technology, Mathura)

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Yes Madam raises ₹50 crore from Info Edge

At-home beauty and wellness platform Yes Madam on Monday said it has raised ₹50 crore in its maiden institutional funding round from Info Edge Growth fund at a valuation of ₹750 crore.

Yes Madam will utilise the fresh capital to accelerate expansion across new cities, technology upgradation and strengthening of its service partner ecosystem, according to a company statement.

The Noida-headquartered firm reported a revenue of ₹195 crore in the financial year 2025-26, registering a more than two-fold jump from ₹94 crore in FY25. The startup had reported a revenue of ₹45 crore in FY24.

Yes Madam currently operates in over 55 cities with a network of more than 12,000 women service professionals.

“My vision has always been to build a platform that customers can rely on for high-quality beauty and wellness services at home, while also solving the industry’s problems. This investment allows us to strengthen that foundation further and disrupt the industry with new innovations and best practices,” Yes Madam co-founder Mayank Arya said.

Gadkari reviews NH projects in Rajasthan, Himachal

Union Minister Nitin Gadkari on Monday directed officials to undertake comprehensive monsoon preparedness, including effective drainage management, to minimise disruptions as he reviewed national highway projects in Rajasthan and Himachal Pradesh.

In the review meetings, Gadkari assessed the quality and maintenance status of National Highways (NHs) covering 10,064 km in Rajasthan and 1,947 km in Himachal Pradesh.

He emphasised timely execution of projects, strict adherence to quality standards, and the adoption of advanced technologies and modern construction practices to ensure the development of sustainable, durable, and efficient highway infrastructure.

The minister highlighted that robust highway networks are vital for improving connectivity, accelerating economic growth, enhancing commuter convenience, and ensuring seamless mobility across key corridors.

He directed officials to undertake comprehensive monsoon preparedness measures, including effective drainage management, slope protection works, proactive preventive maintenance, and swift response mechanisms to minimise disruptions, maintain road safety, and enhance long-term asset durability.

Gold futures rise to ₹1.59 lakh/10g on weak dollar, US-Iran peace deal hopes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Gold prices climbed by ₹426 to ₹1.59 lakh per 10 grams in futures trade on Monday, tracking gains in global markets amid optimism surrounding a possible peace agreement between the US and Iran.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the yellow metal for the June delivery increased by ₹426, or 0.27 per cent, to ₹1,59,105 per 10

grams in a business turnover of 5,312 lots. “Gold prices saw a notable

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | TUESDAY | MAY 26, 2026

BUSINESS 13

High energy costs to weigh on near-term credit: Moody’s

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Moody’s Ratings on Monday said elevated energy prices will weigh on the near-term credit conditions of Indian corporates, despite robust balance sheets and favourable long-term growth prospects.

Stating that Indian corporates are currently in a better financial position to absorb external shocks, supported by deleveraging, healthy liquidity and supportive policy frameworks, Moody’s said persistently high energy prices and structural shifts in key service industries could test

credit strength over the coming quarters.

“Elevated energy prices weigh on near-term credit conditions for Indian corporates, despite strong fundamentals,” it said in a statement.

The conflict in the Middle East will weigh on near-term earnings and cash flows for energy-intensive and fuel-dependent sectors, it added.

“India’s heavy reliance on imported crude oil, liquefied natural gas and certain petroleum products exposes corporates to higher input costs, currency volatility and supply chain disruptions.

“State-owned oil marketing companies and downstream

fuel retailers face acute margin pressure as elevated costs are only partially passed through to consumers, while fuel-intensive sectors such as cement, chemicals, fertilisers and aviation are seeing rising cost burdens,” Moody’s

Ratings Managing Director Vikash Halan said.

Moody’s Ratings India affiliate ICRA expects the operating environment for corporate India in FY2026-27 to be shaped by heightened geopolitical risks, particularly the

Oil marketing companies rally as crude falls sharply

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Shares of oil marketing companies, including BPCL and HPCL, ended higher on Monday, following a sharp correction in crude oil prices and a fresh hike in petrol and diesel prices.

Brent crude, the primary benchmark for global oil prices, fell more than 5 per cent after the US and Iran agreed in principle to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Shares of Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) climbed 4.30 per cent to end at ₹308.25 on the BSE. During the day, the stock advanced 4.55 per cent to hit an intraday high of ₹309.

Hindustan Petroleum

Corporation Ltd (HPCL) stock settled at ₹403.40, up 3.52 per cent, on the BSE. During the day, it jumped 5.86 per cent to hit the day’s high of ₹412.55. Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) rallied 3.15 per cent to ₹143.90. Intraday, the company’s stock advanced 4.15 per cent to ₹145.30.

“At the sectoral level, oil marketing companies (OMCs) continued witnessing strong momentum following recent petrol and diesel price hikes. Stocks such as IOC, BPCL, and HPCL gained sharply as higher retail fuel prices, combined with moderating global crude oil costs, significantly

improved near-term refining and marketing margin expectations,” said Hariprasad K. Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, tanked 5.53 per cent to \$97.81 per barrel. Petrol prices were raised by ₹2.61 a litre and diesel by ₹2.71 on Monday, the fourth increase in less than two weeks that extended a delayed pass-through of soaring global crude oil costs triggered by the Iran conflict.

The latest increase took cumulative hikes since May 15 to nearly ₹7.5 per litre.

The hike came as global oil prices fell sharply amid hopes of a potential deal to end the US-Israel war on Iran.

Adequate availability of fertilisers in country: Govt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Centre on Monday asserted that there is adequate availability of fertilisers in the country to meet the demand of soil nutrients during the upcoming Kharif (summer-sown) season.

At an inter-ministerial briefing on West Asia developments, Aparna S Sharma, Additional Secretary, Department of Fertilizers, said the domestic output post crisis has been good and the country is also importing fertilisers to ensure sufficient supply.

“The overall stock position of fertiliser in the country remains comfortable,” she said.

As against the assessment of 390.54 lakh tonne for Kharif season this year, the stock as on date is 200.12 lakh tonne, the secretary said.

According to Sharma, the

fertilisers stock is more than 50 per cent of projected Kharif demand, significantly higher than the usual 33 per cent.

The Department of Agriculture has assessed the fertiliser requirement for Kharif 2026 at 390.54 lakh tonne. The Kharif sowing operation will begin in June.

Sharma also highlighted that the domestic production and import of fertilisers after the crisis has been substantial.

The total domestic production has been about 95 lakh tonne and about 22.60 lakh tonne of imports have reached Indian shores. So, a total of 117.6 lakh tonne fer-

tilisers have been added to the stock.

The secretary said that the country has already secured 13.5 lakh tonne of DAP and 9 lakh tonne of NPK complexes.

“This will ensure adequate availability during the peak Kharif season,” Sharma said.

The secretary mentioned that the availability of inputs for the production of fertilisers also remains comfortable.

She informed that the Department of Fertiliser is regularly reviewing the situation.

The Empowered Group of Secretary has held nine meetings so far.

“The adequate availability of finished fertilisers and raw materials is being reviewed. The position is stable and well managed,” Sharma said.

In 2025, nearly 73 per cent of the country’s total fertiliser requirement was

met through domestic production.

Total domestic production of fertilisers, including Urea, DAP, NPKs and SSP has increased from 433.29 lakh tonne in 2021 to a record 524.62 lakh tonne in 2025.

India imports a large quantity of urea and Di-ammonium Phosphate (DAP) to meet local demand.

The country’s urea production has increased from 225 lakh tonne during 2014-15 to 306.67 lakh tonne in 2024-25. The country imported more than 100 lakh tonne of urea last fiscal to meet local demand.

The budgetary allocation for fertiliser subsidies in 2026-27 stands at ₹1.71 lakh crore and the import bill is likely to rise as rates in global markets have shot up.

At present, the MRP of neem-coated Urea is ₹242 per bag (45kg), while the DAP is being sold at ₹1,350 per bag (50kg).

India, South Korea begin next round of negotiations on upgrading trade pact

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and South Korea on Monday began the next round of negotiations to upgrade the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), which was implemented in January 2010, an official said.

The three-day talks (May 25-27) are important, as India has flagged serious concerns about the widening trade deficit between the two countries.

“This is the 12th round of India-Korea CEPA upgrade negotiations,” the Government official said. On April 20, Commerce

and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal had proposed to his Korean counterpart, Yeo Han-koo, to consider negotiating a fresh bilateral free trade agreement to make it more contemporary and address concerns over the trade deficit, the difference between imports and exports.

India’s exports to Korea increased 3.31 per cent to \$6 billion in 2025-26 from \$5.81 billion in 2024-25. The export growth was negative during 2022-25.

NBCC Q4 profit rises 37% to ₹241 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned NBCC Ltd on Monday reported a 37 per cent increase in its consolidated net profit to ₹241.38 crore for the quarter ended March 31. Its net profit was ₹175.91 crore in the year-ago period. The total income fell to ₹4,618.59 crore during the fourth quarter of 2025-26 from ₹4,700.86 crore in the corresponding period of the preceding year, according to a regulatory filing.

During the full 2025-26 fiscal, the company’s net profit rose to ₹720.03 crore from ₹541.13 crore in the preceding fiscal year. Its total

present an additional layer of uncertainty. El Nino-like conditions could disrupt monsoon distribution, weighing on rural incomes and discretionary spending, it added.

“While government support measures and minimum support price interventions could partially mitigate income risks, a weaker agricultural outcome could temper rural discretionary consumption.

“Accordingly, there could be downward pressure on demand in sectors like tractors, two-wheelers, FMCGs and construction materials linked to rural housing,” ICRA, EVP and Chief Ratings Officer, K Ravichandran said.

income climbed to ₹13,195.88 crore in the last fiscal from ₹12,272.99 crore in 2024-25.

NBCC Ltd is engaged in project management consultancy (PMC), real estate and EPC (engineering, procurement and construction) sectors. The Board of Directors recommended a final dividend of ₹0.46 (46 per cent) per paid-up equity share of ₹1 each (subject to deduction of TDS) for 2025-26.

PAYTM ARM TO INVEST 9 MILLION EURO IN EUROPEAN SUBSIDIARY

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Fintech firm One 97 Communications, which operates under the Paytm brand, on Monday said its wholly-owned subsidiary Paytm Cloud Technologies will invest 9 million euro in its European payment entity.

“...The Board of Directors of PCTL (Paytm Cloud Technologies Limited)...has approved an additional investment by way of subscription to 9 million equity shares of EUR 1 (one euro only) each at a total consideration of EUR 9 million (nine million euro), in its wholly-owned subsidiary, Paytm Europe Payments S.A (Paytm Europe),” the company said in a filing.

The transaction is aimed at increasing the paid-up capital of Paytm Europe to support the funding requirements for its business. The transaction is expected to be completed on or before June 30, 2026, the company said.

Paytm Europe Payments SA, incorporated in Luxembourg on January 12, 2026, is a step-down wholly-owned subsidiary of One 97 Communications.

RBI tightens norms for re-appointment of directorsto Urban Co-operative Banks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

An individual cannot serve as a director continuously for more than 10 years on the board of Urban Co-operative Banks, and the re-appointment can happen only after a compulsory three-year cooling-off period, according to the RBI.

Amending the provisions, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Monday said there have been instances where directors resorted to circumventing statutory provisions to continue on the boards of the UCBS.

In certain cases, the RBI said directors resigned briefly from office and got reelect-

ed/co-opted to the board within a short period, thereby continuing to be on the Board for an extended period beyond the legally permissible tenure.

The Reserve Bank of India (Urban Co-operative Banks — Governance) Amendment Directions, 2026, have come into force with immediate effect.

“A director on the Board of a UCB, after completing a

continuous tenure of ten years in office, shall be eligible to be re-appointed, whether by election or co-option or in any other manner, as a director on the Board of the same UCB only after undergoing a minimum cooling-off period of three years,” according to the directions.

During the cooling-off period, the said director shall not be associated with the UCB in any capacity/manner other than as a member/customer, it added.

“This, however, shall not preclude him/her from being appointed as a director on the Board of another bank, if otherwise eligible,” the RBI said.

SEBI bans 7 individuals in ₹20-cr stock manipulation case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Capital markets regulator SEBI has barred seven individuals from securities markets for allegedly running a coordinated pump-and-dump scheme across social media platforms and making unlawful gains of over ₹20.25 crore.

Apart from the debarment, the regulator has also directed finfluencer Hemant Gupta and his sons, Rohan Gupta and Aniket Gupta, to immediately cease and desist from offering unregistered research analyst services or from portraying themselves as research analysts.

In a 234-page interim order passed on May 22, Sebi alleged that Hemant, Rohan

and Aniket acted as “Operators” who first accumulated positions in thinly traded SME stocks and later circulated bullish stock recommendations on social media platforms to inflate prices, before selling their holdings at a profit.

Four other family members — Sharon, Leana,

Rajani and Purvangi Gupta — allegedly facilitated the operation by allowing the use of their trading accounts or by executing trades on the operators’ instructions, the order said.

“The on-going investigation has prima facie highlighted the scheme and device orchestrated intri-

cately by noticees whereby the operators by posting stock recommendations on various scrips on their X Accounts and social media platforms induced the general public to deal in the securities purely based on misleading and unsolicited stock tips, and thus enabling the beneficiaries to liquidate their holdings at an inflated price,” SEBI’s Whole Time Member Kamlesh C Varshney said in the order.

According to Sebi, the scheme involved 82 scrips during the examination period from December 1, 2023, to January 20, 2026.

Sebi said Rohan and Aniket posted bullish updates on their X handles, ‘@WealthSolitaire’ and ‘@desiwallstreet’. On the

other hand, Hemant amplified these recommendations across several WhatsApp and Telegram groups, often adding explicitly target prices and deliberately keeping such communications off X, to avoid regulatory scrutiny.

The regulator noted that the combined gross traded value of the seven individuals rose 86 per cent from ₹548 crore in the pre-examination period to ₹1,023 crore during the examination period.

Further, their total squared-off profits surged 242 per cent to ₹58.40 crore. Among them, Rohan and Sharon Gupta emerged as the biggest beneficiaries with profits of ₹50.03 crore, according to the order.

PRAGATI 2026 enhances regional military cooperation in Meghalaya

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Umroi (Meghalaya)

The maiden edition of multinational joint military Exercise PRAGATI 2026, currently underway at Umroi, has entered an intensive operational phase with the participation of more than 400 military personnel from 12 friendly nations.

The exercise, which began on May 20, aims to enhance regional peace, security and defence cooperation through joint training and professional exchanges among participating armies. Conducted in the spirit of equality, friendship and mutual respect, the multinational engagement is providing a platform for troops to improve interoperability and share operational best practices in a challenging environment.

One of the key highlights of the exercise has been the formation of integrated mixed teams comprising



personnel from all participating nations. These teams have been training together in semi-mountainous and jungle terrain over the past few days, carrying out specialised drills including rock craft, ambush and counter-ambush operations, slithering exercises, jungle lane shooting and bus intervention procedures.

To further sharpen combat skills and operational proficiency, sniper

firing and AK-203 rifle shooting competitions have also been organised during the exercise. Officials said these activities are helping participants build confidence, improve tactical coordination and gain professional insights from one another.

Apart from combat-oriented training, Exercise PRAGATI 2026 has also placed emphasis on strengthening camaraderie among troops through

sports and informal interactions. Military personnel from participating nations took part in basketball, volleyball and tug-of-war competitions, fostering teamwork, trust and stronger interpersonal ties.

Defence officials noted that the exercise reflects the collective commitment of regional partners to address common security challenges through cooperation, mutual learning and joint preparedness.

Massive public participation marks Jan Bhagidari Abhiyan in Kamrup district

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amingaon

Kamrup District witnessed extensive public participation during the Jan Bhagidari Abhiyan conducted under the ongoing Jan Jatiya Garima Utsav 2026, with nearly 4,000 citizens taking part in Jan Sunwai programmes, health camps and awareness activities across remote and rural areas of the district.

The week-long campaign, organised from May 18 to 25, was conducted across all four Development Blocks of the district and covered 64 villages through 34 Adi Sewa Kendras. The outreach initiative engaged a wide section of the population, including women, youth, senior citizens and persons with disabilities.

Officials said the campaign was aimed at bringing Government services closer to people through coordinated efforts involving multiple departments, frontline workers, local institutions, self-help groups and community leaders.

During the Jan Sunwai pro-



grammes, residents directly interacted with Government officials and raised issues concerning welfare schemes, drinking water supply, road infrastructure, Aadhaar-related services, ration cards, healthcare facilities and livelihood support.

According to district authorities, more than 3,900 grievances and public concerns were recorded during the campaign. Several issues were resolved on the spot, while the remaining cases were forwarded to concerned departments for follow-up action within stip-

ulated timelines.

Health camps organised alongside the public hearing programmes provided medical consultations and preventive healthcare awareness to residents in underserved areas. Information regarding various Government health schemes was also disseminated during the outreach drives.

Officials described the initiative as an important step towards strengthening grassroots governance and improving accessibility to public services in rural and remote communities of the district.

Manas Mitra Programme engages over 1,500 students in conservation awareness initiatives

TONY DAS
■ Barpeta Road (Assam)

Manas National Park and Tiger Reserve has intensified its community outreach efforts through the Manas Mitra Programme, an initiative aimed at strengthening ties between local communities and wildlife conservation through educational activities and nature-based experiences for students.

Launched on November 14, 2024, at the Bansbari Range on the occasion of Children's Day, the "Manas Mitra Programme" — meaning "Friends of Manas" — seeks to promote conservation awareness among people living in fringe villages surrounding the reserve, with a special focus on students and youth.

As part of the programme, Nature Orientation sessions have been conducted since February 2026 across 22 schools in villages bordering the reserve.

The awareness campaign has so far reached 1,537 students, educating them on

DD National revamps prime-time line-up with classic shows, family entertainment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Doordarshan National is set to launch a refreshed prime-time entertainment lineup featuring a mix of quiz shows, social dramas and comedy programmes aimed at bringing family audiences back to television screens.

The public broadcaster announced that the new programming slate will focus on wholesome entertainment combining knowledge, social awareness and family values, while also reviving nostalgia through the return of several iconic television formats.

Among the biggest highlights is the return of the popular quiz show Kaun Banega Crorepati, which will air Monday to Friday at 9 PM on Doordarshan National. Hosted by veteran actor Amitabh Bachchan, the show has long been regarded as one of India's most successful knowledge-based television programmes.

Officials said the show would continue its tradition of showcasing inspiring stories of ordinary Indians while testing contestants on subjects ranging from Indian culture and history to sports, science, cinema and current affairs.

Doordarshan National will also introduce RAJINI 2.0, a contemporary social



drama centred around a strong female protagonist dealing with social challenges and family issues. The programme, scheduled to air at 8 PM from Monday to Friday, aims to blend social messaging with emotional storytelling.

In the comedy segment, viewers will see the launch of Office Office — Chali Musaddi Ki Beti, a new adaptation inspired by the cult satire series "Office Office." The show will portray the struggles of common citizens through humour and satire while highlighting contemporary social issues. It will air at 8:30 PM on weekdays.

The broadcaster said the revamped lineup has been designed to appeal to audiences across generations by combining entertainment with meaningful and relatable content.

All the programmes will also be available on Waves OTT, allowing viewers to stream content on mobile phones, tablets and smart televisions.

Officials stated that the initiative reflects Doordarshan National's continued effort to promote Indian culture, family-oriented storytelling and socially relevant entertainment while adapting to evolving digital viewing habits.

NTPC starts site selection studies in Guj, Andhra, Odisha, MP for nuclear projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned NTPC has initiated site selection studies in four States, including Gujarat and Andhra Pradesh, to set up nuclear projects as part of its long-term 30 GW nuclear energy plan.

The other two States are Odisha and Madhya Pradesh, according to a post-earnings presentation of NTPC.



As part of its energy diversification strategy, NTPC is looking to set up 30 GW of nuclear projects in at least 14 States with investments worth lakhs of crores to contribute to the Government's ambitious 100 GW nuclear capacity target by 2047.

The company has "identified potential sites in multiple States and site selection studies commenced in Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat and Odisha", NTPC said in the presentation.

It will be beneficial for NTPC to set up projects in the coastal States, as out of various other inputs, continuous water supply is a key requirement for a nuclear project, an expert said.

Earlier, sources said NTPC will soon submit its first feasibility study for a nuclear project with the Department of Atomic Energy (DAE) to seek its approval.

DAILY SUDOKU

			3					7
	7			5		6		3
	3	4		7	8			
	9	7			5			
			9				8	2
			8	4		5	6	
9		6		3				1
1					9			

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

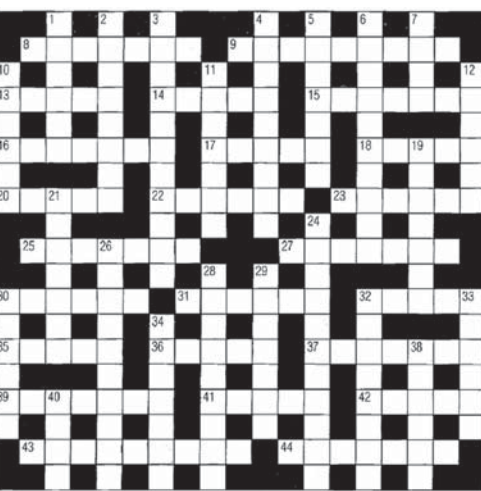
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (25.5.26)

6	2	1	5	3	8	9	4	7
5	3	8	9	4	7	2	6	1
4	9	7	2	6	1	5	3	8
8	6	3	7	1	5	4	9	2
1	5	2	4	9	3	7	8	6
9	7	4	6	8	2	3	1	5
2	1	6	3	5	4	8	7	9
7	4	9	8	2	6	1	5	3
3	8	5	1	7	9	6	2	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD TUESDAY | MAY 26, 2026



ACROSS

- 8 Ruin the opening (7)
- 9 The plumber's fantasy? (4,5)
- 13 Go on and on about how you're at home in? (5)
- 14 Categorise as students (5)
- 15 Book, though it's a formality (7)
- 16 Drop back after the right turn, please (7)
- 17 Agrees to a change of name (5)
- 18 The painting has been returned to once more (5)
- 20 Shot in the avenue (5)
- 22 Figures accommodation will include it (7)
- 23 Anything but a bad hat! (6)
- 25 The fish swim back, hemming in the non-swimmers (7)
- 27 Corroborate it's to do with business (7)

DOWN

- 1 Not thoroughly out of sorts? (6)
- 2 In a terribly close round, breakdown (8)
- 3 Having been sold, was demolished (7,4)
- 4 The very good trees, treat differently (5)
- 5 Be told the time has come to give encouragement (7)
- 6 Fed up to find the ring isn't really gold? (7,3)
- 7 Just as lovely (4)
- 10 Either got dead worried about it or loved it (6)
- 11 Trip the fool attendant coming out (7)
- 12 Go off with the agent to have a look (6)
- 19 A ribbon, brightly coloured and narrower at one end than the

- 30 In about an hour, the murderer's in shackles (6)
- 31 "24" turns a little to give a sign (6)
- 32 Goes along with, as the second date (5)
- 35 Give a seat to somebody who's standing (5)
- 36 Say yes, it is about time to capture (5)
- 37 Championed the conceited (5-2)
- 39 The porter is prepared to carry one for the entertainer (7)
- 41 Man with a degree in music (5)
- 42 At that point, giving an exclamation of triumph (5)
- 43 Always take it in good part. Don't worry (5,4)
- 44 Lets slip about the vehicle and is very embarrassed (7)

other (7)

- 21 Copy and I get a friend to frame it (7)
- 24 As an example, France is not bad (3,8)
- 26 Not being a novice, he's not running in the race (3-7)
- 28 Once more there to act as proxy (9)
- 29 The cover-up woman is the problem (7)
- 30 Feeling of revulsion sneaks give you (6)
- 32 They don't open the covers (8)
- 33 Exceptionally quiet during the meal (6)
- 34 "A leisure activity that's beyond me," I put in (7)
- 38 He maintains a uniform usually goes with his job (6)
- 40 Quits the flat (4)angler (4)
- 33 Grand antique, precious (4)



Assam Governor Lakshman Prasad Acharya and Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma with the Prime Minister of Bhutan Dasho Tshering Tobgay in Lok Bhavan

IRFC signs ₹13,527 cr refinancing deal for Hyderabad Metro project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian Railway Finance Corporation Ltd (IRFC) has signed a ₹13,527 crore term loan agreement with L&T Metro Rail (Hyderabad) Limited to refinance the debt obligations of the Hyderabad Metro Rail project, marking one of the largest refinancing transactions in India's urban transit sector.

The agreement, signed on Monday, is being seen as a major step in strengthening long-term financing for urban mobility infrastructure and reflects IRFC's expanding role beyond traditional railway financing. The loan agreement was signed in the presence of IRFC Chairman and Managing Director Manoj Kumar Dubey and Telangana Chief Secretary K. Ramakrishna Rao.

According to IRFC, the refinancing aligns with the



Government of India's vision of "Viksit Bharat" and demonstrates the corporation's growing capability to provide long-tenor financing solutions for large infrastructure projects.

Speaking on the occasion, Dubey said the transaction underlined IRFC's commitment to supporting sustainable urban mobility through efficient capital mobilisation and innovative financing structures.

The refinancing follows the transfer of 100 per cent ownership of L&T Metro Rail

(Hyderabad) Limited from Larsen & Toubro Limited to the Government of Telangana through Hyderabad Metro Rail Limited, effectively bringing the metro network under State ownership.

Officials said the funding facility would refinance existing liabilities, including non-convertible debentures (NCDs), commercial papers and term loans, thereby enabling an orderly exit for existing lenders while improving the long-term financial sustainability

of the metro project. Hyderabad Metro Rail Phase-I spans 69.2 kilometres across three corridors with 57 stations and is considered among the world's largest metro rail projects developed under the public-private partnership (PPP) model.

The metro network currently serves more than five lakh passenger journeys daily and forms a key component of Hyderabad's public transport infrastructure.

PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
MARINE DEPARTMENT
No.MD/SHS/TECH-123/2026/632
Dated, the 21st May, 2026
e-TENDER CALL NOTICE (e-TCN)

Name of the Work: "Providing Assistance for Monitoring Maintenance Dredging Operation and Assisting Hydrographic Survey and other Miscellaneous works of Hydrographic Survey Division, Marine Department, PPA for a period of 03(three) years". Estimated cost: Rs.1,21,79,811/- Plus GST. Last date & time of submission of tender through on-line bidding is 17:00 Hours on Dt.11.06.2026. For details, please log on to the Website: <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>.

Sd/- Deputy Conservator,
Paradip Port Authority

PPA/PR/10/2026-2027 dtd. 25.05.2026

BRIEFLY

Nishesh Basavareddy stuns Taylor Fritz in French Open



Indian-origin tennis player Nishesh Basavareddy caused the first major upset of the French Open as he stunned seventh-seeded American Taylor Fritz in the opening round.

Wild card entrant Basavareddy, an American citizen now, beat world number nine Fritz 7-6(5), 7-6(5), 6-7(9), 6-1 in a gruelling match that lasted two hours and 45 minutes on Sunday to reach the second round.

The 21-year-old, whose parents moved to the USA from Nellore in Andhra Pradesh in 1999, became the first American man to beat a top-10 opponent at Roland Garros since Jan-Michael Gambill eliminated then-World No. 8 Nicolas Kiefer in 2000.

He was aggressive early, using plenty of drop shots and his backhand down the line. He also withstood 71 winners from Fritz, hitting 51 of his own to claim the first Top-10 victory of his career.

Basavareddy had played just five tour-level matches this season when he walked on court against Fritz. (PTI)

Swiatek not taking anything for granted at French Open



It was a massive mismatch on paper and that's the way it ended up on court, too. Four-time champion Iga Swiatek required exactly one hour to eliminate 136th-ranked French Open debutante Emerson Jones 6-1, 6-2 in the first round on Monday, in front of a mostly empty Court Philippe-Chatrier on another steamy day in Paris.

The only real issue for the third-ranked Swiatek came when she needed a trainer to re-tape the middle finger on her tennis-playing right hand for an apparent blister after the first set.

"I'm just really happy to play on this court," she said. "First matches are always also for getting used to the condition tactically and type of the ball."

Swiatek has not won a title on clay this season and recently made a coaching change. She hired Francisco Roig, who previously worked with record 14-time French Open champion Rafael Nadal.

"Nothing comes easy," Swiatek said. "With more titles it's even a bit harder because everyone expects you to be ready always and play perfectly. So you need to stay humble and not take anything for granted and work your way from the beginning of the tournament."

She improved to 28-1 in first-round matches at Grand Slams. (AP)

Saptak finishes T-40 in Denmark, as Tapio Pulkkanen wins title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Odense (Denmark)

Indian golfer Saptak Talwar followed up two indifferent rounds in the middle with a strong final round to finish at T-40 at the Danish Golf Challenge. He carded 4-under 68 to take his total score for the week to 8-under par (67-70-75-68).

Talwar, who finished second at the DP World PGTI Open, an event co-sanctioned between the PGTI Tour and the DP World Tour, is now 21st on the Road to Mallorca Standings, from which 15 cards are available for 2026 DP World Tour. Talwar, who leads the PGTI Order of Merit, can also go to the DP World Tour, in case he wins the PGTI Order of Merit, like Yuvraj Sandhu did in 2025.

Tapio Pulkkanen beat Maxence Giboudot in a play-off to win the title after both players finished at 18-under par to go into a sudden death for the title. Pulkkanen won the play-off to claim his second HotelPlanner Tour title at Odense Eventyr Golf.

Talwar made six birdies and two bogeys in his final round of the week. He began the round with a bogey before making three consecutive



TALWAR, WHO FINISHED SECOND AT THE DP WORLD PGTI OPEN, IS NOW 21ST ON THE ROAD TO MALLORCA STANDINGS, FROM WHICH 15 CARDS ARE AVAILABLE FOR 2026 DP WORLD TOUR

birdies and a fourth birdie on the eighth hole to be 3-under par for the day at the turn. On the back nine, he picked up shots on the 11th and 14th holes before dropping a shot on the 15th hole and closed the round at 4-under par.

Pulkkanen and Giboudot were locked in a close battle. After 15 holes in the final round, Giboudot led the field but a bogey on the 16th hole opened him to a challenge from Pulkkanen, who was able to birdie the 18th hole for the third day in a row to force the play-off.

The pair then had 30-foot putts for eagle on the first play-off hole. Pulkkanen eagled the first play-off hole despite the Frenchman making a birdie. It was the Finn's third eagle of the week that cemented the title.

Sandhu finishes T-63, Sterne wins after 13 yrs



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Rinkven (Belgium)

Indian golfer Yuvraj Sandhu endured a difficult final day to finish T-63 at the Soudal Open. The 29-year-old is playing his debut season on the DP World Tour. Sandhu carded his only over par round of 73 on the final day and finished with a score of 5-under par with rounds of 70-68-68-73.

The winner this week was South Africa's Richard Sterne, a seven-time winner on the DP World Tour who won his last title over 13 years ago.

Sterne had a total score of 18-under par (64-68-68-66).

The other Indian in the field this week was Shubhankar Sharma, who missed the cut for the third successive start. He last made the cut at the Turkish Airlines Open back in March. Sandhu struggled in his final round of the week as he saw a pair of bogeys on the fifth and sixth holes and another on the 13th hole before making his only birdie of the day on the 15th.

This saw him card a final round of 2-over 73 to drop down more than 30 places from T-32 to T-63.

MoS Sports reviews progress of National Sports University

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State for Youth Affairs & Sports, Raksha Khadse, on Monday visited the National Sports University (NSU), Imphal, where she reviewed the progress of its permanent campus and interacted with athletes, students, coaches, and officials associated with the institution.

She also visited the Sports Authority of India (SAI) National Centre of Excellence (NCOE), Imphal, as part of her review of the sports ecosystem in the region.

During the visit, the minister was accompanied by Daljit Singh Chawdhary, Vice-Chancellor, National Sports University; N. Praveen Singh, Secretary, Sports,

Government of Manipur; C Dhandapani, Regional Director, SAI; along with senior officials of the National Sports University and the Sports Authority of India.

Early in the morning, Khadse joined athletes during their daily training sessions and participated in fitness and conditioning activities alongside them. She interacted with athletes and coaches while observing warm-up drills, endurance training, stretching exercises, mobility routines, and sport-specific practice sessions.

Appreciating the dedication and discipline displayed by the athletes, the minister encouraged them to continue striving for excellence and make the country proud on interna-



tional platforms. At the National Sports University's permanent campus at Koutruk in Imphal West District, Khadse undertook a detailed review of the ongoing construction and infrastructure development works. Spread across nearly 325 acres, the campus is nearing completion, with approximately 95 per cent of the work already completed.

The minister reviewed major facilities being developed within the campus, including the administrative block, academic complexes equipped with smart classrooms and laboratories, library, auditorium, sports science facilities, and residential hostels designed to accommodate nearly 1,300 students and around 60 faculty members.

Ravi, Sharad moves CAT for regularisation of Govt jobs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Tokyo Olympics silver medalist wrestler Ravi Kumar Dahiya and Paralympic high jumper Sharad Kumar have approached the Central Administrative Tribunal seeking regularisation of their services as Assistant Directors of Education (Sports) with the Delhi Government, alleging that they have been kept on repeated ad hoc extensions despite discharging regular administrative duties for years.

In separate but similarly worded petitions, the two athletes argued that they had left secure government



jobs to join the Government of NCT of Delhi after being offered Group 'A' positions in recognition of their international achievements and with an expectation of eventual regularisation.

Sharad, a bronze medalist at the Tokyo Paralympics



and silver medalist at the Paris Paralympics, stated that he had resigned from a permanent position with the Sports Authority of India, where he had served as athletics (Para) coach, to join the Delhi government in 2022.

The petitions contended that although the appointments were initially described as ad hoc for six months or till regular appointment, the memoranda also contained a two-year probation clause, creating a "legitimate expectation" that the athletes' services would eventually be regularised.

Both athletes said they have continued to perform "perennial Governmental functions" in the Sports Branch, including supervision of selection trials, inspection of stadiums and sports centres, evaluation of coaches and work related to Khelo India programmes.

Samrat, Babuta to lead in ISSF World Cup Rifle



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Munich

Two finals in the men's 10m air pistol and 10m air rifle events are scheduled on the opening day of competitions at the Munich leg of the ISSF World Cup Rifle/Pistol on Tuesday with Samrat Rana and Arjun Babuta leading the Indian challenge.

Traditionally billed as a blue-riband annual event in the sport, the German capital will see participation of 696 shooters from 80 countries, including a galaxy of Olympic and world champions.

The 22-member Indian squad has a healthy mix of experience and youth and will be up against the royalty of rifle and pistol shooting.

The India squad includes four debutants in the senior level – Suraj Sharma, Sakshi Padekar, Ajendra Singh Chauhan and Udhayveer Sidhu

who is making his debut in a senior world cup or an Olympic event. Apart from the 22-member squad, 13 athletes will also be competing in Munich for ranking points.

10m Air Pistol Men

World champion Samrat Rana will lead the Indian challenge in the 10m air pistol event along with Sharvan Kumar and debutant Ajendra Singh Chauhan. The trio will be up against some of the best pistol shooters in the world starting with China's Hu Kai who clinched the gold medal in all four world cups last year and the World Cup final title along with a silver behind Samrat in the World Championships.

The other challengers in the event include 19-year-old Bu Shuaihang of China who won gold in Granada last month, German pistol legend Christian Reitz, Paris Olympics medalists Federico Nilo Maldini.

Injured Yamal and Williams in Spain's World Cup squad

TALES AZZONIAP ■ Madrid

Injured forwards Lamine Yamal and Nico Williams were included in Spain's World Cup squad.

Yamal and Williams sustained muscle injuries late in the season but coach Luis de la Fuente said he expects them to be fit for the start of the World Cup. Spain opens its campaign against Cape Verde in Group H on June 15 in Atlanta. It then faces Saudi Arabia on June 21 in Atlanta and Uruguay on June 26 in Guadalajara, Mexico.

For the first time there won't be a Real Madrid player in a Spain World Cup



party. Defender Dean Huijsen was among the contenders for a place but he was left out by De la Fuente.

Out as expected was Barcelona midfielder Fermin Lopez, who sustained a fracture on his right foot this month. Midfielder Mikel Merino, who played only once for Arsenal since injuring his foot in January, is back in the Spain squad. Also included despite a recent injury is Paris Saint-Germain midfielder Fabian Ruiz.

Spain's preparations will begin on Saturday. It plays warmup matches against Iraq on June 4 and Peru on June 9. It rebounded from a round-of-16 elimination by Morocco at the 2022 World Cup by winning Euro

2024 in Germany. La Roja also won the 2023 Nations League and was runner-up to Portugal in the 2025 edition. Spain hasn't gone further than the last 16 in the World Cup since its lone title triumph in 2010.

Squad:

Goalkeepers: Unai Simon (Athletic Bilbao), David Raya (Arsenal), Joan Garcia (Barcelona)

Defenders: Marc Cucurella (Chelsea), Alejandro Grimaldo (Bayer Leverkusen), Marcos Llorente (Atletico Madrid), Pau Cubarsi (Barcelona), Aymeric Laporte (Athletic Bilbao), Pedro Porro (Tottenham), Eric Garcia (Barcelona), Marc Pubill (Atletico Madrid). (AP)



Tottenham leadership promises change after team averts Premier League relegation disaster

STEVE DOUGLASAP ■ London

"Uncomfortable truths" have come to the surface. For Tottenham's players and leadership, there was little to celebrate after the club – one of the richest in European soccer – narrowly escaped relegation from England's top division for the first time in nearly 50 years. "We will not dress it up," Chairman Peter Charrington said in a letter to fans published Monday, "as anything other than falling well short of what this club expects."

While Tottenham's 17th-place finish last season was viewed as an aberration amid the team's ultimately successful bid to win the Europa League, there was little excuse – except, maybe, a long list of injuries – for a repeat 12 months later.

Yet there Spurs were, heading into the final round of this season on Sunday, just two points

outside the relegation zone and in danger of dropping into the second tier for the first time since 1977.

It would have been the most unlikely relegation since the Premier League was founded in 1992, with Tottenham a member of England's so-called "Big Six," at the forefront of plans to launch the quickly-aborted Super League just five years ago, and owner of one of the most stunning stadiums in Europe.

However, Tottenham beat Everton 1-0 – rendering third-to-last West Ham's win over Leeds irrelevant – to complete a late-season revival that included three wins in its last five games under recently-hired coach Roberto De Zerbi, who was brought in late in March to lead the rescue act.

"Without that appointment," Tottenham midfielder James Maddison said, "disaster could have maybe struck. "But it didn't." It was too close for comfort,



though, for a club hierarchy that has undergone profound change over the last couple of years, including the departure of long-time chairman Daniel Levy in September – five months after the arrival of Vinai Venkatesham as chief executive, a role he previously performed at fierce-rival Arsenal.

Charrington said that during this "full reset" of the boardroom, the club had taken its eye off the ball. "As part of that process, we discovered some uncomfortable truths. The qualities that make Spurs distinct, our football, our ambition, the connection between the team and its supporters, had been allowed to fade," he wrote in his open letter.

"Football success had not been driving our decisions."

Charrington gave a five-point list of commitments to fans, including that the club "will invest across multiple transfer windows to

rebuild, balance and strengthen" the team for De Zerbi, who was given a five-year deal when he joined. "There has been speculation about ownership and the future direction of the club," Charrington added. "Let us be direct. Tottenham Hotspur is not for sale. The Lewis family are wholly committed to this club and to this rebuild."

"They will provide the stability and investment needed at every level to move us forward, and they see that as a long-term responsibility, not a short-term fix." Maddison is happy De Zerbi, the former Brighton and Marseille coach, will be leading Tottenham through tough times.

"I am really happy for the manager who came in and steered the ship clear," Maddison said, "Because I think without him, it could have been doom and gloom, if I am honest."

RCB, GT set for high-stakes Qualifier 1 in Dharamsala

AMANPREET SINGH ■ Dharamsala

The evidence from the three IPL matches played in Dharamsala this season suggests that it has evolved into a high-scoring venue where fast bowlers still remain relevant, a combination that could shape Tuesday's Qualifier 1 between Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Gujarat Titans.

The numbers tell the story clearly. Across the three completed matches at the HPCA Stadium this season, every first-innings total has either touched or crossed 200.

So while Dharamsala continues to offer seam movement and bounce, the old perception of it being a purely bowler-friendly venue no longer fully applies. The true carry has created conditions where batters can dominate once they survive the opening overs.

What remains unique, however, is how the ball behaves early in the innings. At roughly 1,450 metres



above sea level, Dharamsala remains one of the few Indian grounds where fast bowlers consistently get conventional swing alongside steep carry. The cooler, thin mountain air helps seamers hit hard lengths effectively, especially with the new ball.

But unlike venues where assistance for pacers translates into

low totals, Dharamsala's outfield and even bounce allows batters to recover rapidly after the initial movement. That pattern has repeated itself in all three matches this season: wickets and play-and-miss chances in the powerplay followed by heavy scoring once the ball softened. The tactical battle in Qualifier 1 may there-

fore depend on which side maximises the first six overs with the ball. On current evidence, RCB appear to hold a slight edge in those conditions.

Their pace attack, led by Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Josh Hazlewood, is built more around control, swing and hard-length execution. These are attributes that have historically worked in Dharamsala. Bowlers capable of moving the ball under lights and varying pace intelligently at the death have enjoyed success here even in high-scoring games.

Against Punjab Kings, RCB could defend 222 because their seamers kept striking during the chase.

GT's attack, meanwhile, arguably possesses greater raw pace, which the extra carry in Dharamsala could amplify. But one factor that may reduce their usual advantage is the limited role of spin at this venue. Rashid Khan is usually effective but this pitch will test him.

Statistical trends from recent matches here show pacers accounting for the overwhelming majority of wickets, with teams rarely turning extensively to spin in decisive phases.

Another significant trend is toss dominance.

Chasing sides have won two of the three matches this season, largely because batting becomes easier once the ball loses shine and dew settles in. That could make bowling first the preferred option again on Tuesday night.

Overall, Qualifier 1 is unlikely to be a traditional "bowler's match" despite Dharamsala's reputation. The surface now rewards aggressive batting far more than before, but it still offers enough early movement to keep fast bowlers central to the contest. In that regard, RCB's more rounded seam attack may give them a marginal advantage over GT in exploiting the venue's most decisive phase: the powerplay. (PTI)

DC paid the price for not seizing crucial moments, says Head Coach Badani



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Delhi Capitals head coach Hemang Badani admitted that his side failed to produce consistent performances through the season and paid the price for not capitalising on key moments in crucial matches. DC ended their 2026 IPL campaign in sixth place with seven wins and as many defeats, falling short of the playoffs for the fifth year running.

There were several matches where DC came

close to winning but failed to cross the line. They suffered a heartbreaking one-run defeat against Gujarat Titans at home and were also unable to defend a massive total of 264 against Punjab Kings.

To add to their woes, there were dropped catches galore which proved to be decisive in their losses against Chennai Super Kings and Sunrisers Hyderabad.

"There were many games that I genuinely felt that could go either way. And we did not seize those moments," Badani said at

the post-match press conference on Sunday.

"One being the Gujarat game, we lost the game by one run. The 264 is again something that you would fancy yourself to defend that score. Even with CSK, we dropped some catches. With SRH, we dropped some catches at a crucial time of the game."

Their batting unit frequently lost wickets in clusters, while the bowling attack lacked penetration throughout the season. DC bowlers managed only 64 wickets in



14 games, the joint-lowest tally among all teams.

"Even with us batting, we did not many a times hold on to our wickets. We have lost too many in clusters, if you go back and see the stats," Badani said. "And as a bowling side, you ideally want to pick a lot of wickets. If you see the stats with sides picking wickets, I think we are right at the bottom."

"I think a culmination of all of it is the reason why we are at 14 points and we could have been a lot better than that."

Thoughts of stepping down never came to me, says Ajinkya Rahane

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Kolkata Knight Riders captain Ajinkya Rahane said thoughts of stepping down never crossed his mind despite the side's disastrous start to the IPL season, adding that it is important to show character when the team is struggling.

The former champions endured a miserable start to their IPL campaign, losing five of their opening six matches and sinking to the bottom of the points table.

However, they staged a remarkable turnaround by winning six of their final eight games, briefly reviving hopes of a playoff qualification before eventually falling short.

"For me, I've played cricket all my life with a good attitude. Character has always been very important for me," Rahane said at the post match press confer-

ence after the team's last game of the season.

KKR lost by 40 runs against Delhi Capitals on Sunday.

"I'm never one to back down. When the team is down, when the team is struggling, it's very important to show your character at that time. I am never one that steps down. When the team is struggling, it is important to show your character."

"Yes, there's pressure. It's very natural but the pressure is on those who are privileged. Not everyone can handle the pressure. For me, it was important to stay strong and not panic. It's very easy when you lose 5-6 matches, your focus shifts to the past and the future."



Rahane himself endured an underwhelming campaign with the bat. The veteran opener scored 335 runs in 14 matches at a strike rate of 135. His strike rate outside the Powerplay was also among the lowest in the competition.

"It's important that you stay in that moment. Things can turn around any time. We've seen in a lot of matches and series how things change. It's very important to maintain that attitude and character. I'm never one to back down. Those thoughts (of stepping down) never came to me," added Rahane, who famously led the Indian Test team to the 2020-21 Border-Gavaskar title after a disastrous 36 all out. Wanted to give

time to Indian bowlers

KKR's campaign was disrupted even before it began, with several key players, including pacers Harshit Rana and Akash Deep, suffering injuries. The franchise was also forced to release Bangladesh pacer Mustafizur Rahman on instructions of the BCCI in the wake of diplomatic tensions between the two countries, leaving their bowling attack severely depleted.

Rahane said the setbacks prompted him to back domestic Indian talent.

"We lost a few players during the season and it's challenging all the time, but I was not looking at that. I was confident about and wanted to give time to the Indian bowlers. I knew that, I was confident that if we back them, if we give them that time, they will do really well under pressure."

Captain defends team's decision to play Varun Chakaravarth with injury

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Kolkata Knight Riders captain Ajinkya Rahane said the decision to continue playing mystery spinner Varun Chakaravarth despite a fractured left toe was taken only after clearance from the medical staff.

Chakaravarth suffered a hairline fracture earlier this month during KKR's clash against Sunrisers Hyderabad when a straight drive from Ishan Kishan struck his shoe. It was the third fracture the spinner sustained this season, having earlier played through two finger fractures on his non-bowling left hand.

"See, our team's physios and the physios of BCCI



and the Indian team, there was a discussion among them. I don't get involved in that at all. That's their department. My department is how's the player's mindset, does the player want to play or not, how big is the risk?" Rahane told

reporters after KKR's final league match on Sunday.

"Yes, it's important to consider the health factor, to stay fit. Your injuries shouldn't increase. Yes, we think about that. But the physios felt that his injuries won't increase."

Brazil turns to Carlo Ancelotti to end long wait for World Cup glory

MAURICIO SAVARESE ■ Sao Paulo

Brazil's biggest hope to end a 24-year World Cup title drought is not a clinical striker, a creative midfielder or a dribbling winger like in previous editions of the tournament. This time Brazilians are pinning their hopes on a 66-year-old Italian, who will be sitting on the bench.

Carlo Ancelotti, one of the most successful coaches of his generation, left Real Madrid to take over Brazil's national team last year, a rare example of a foreign coach in charge of the Selecao. Even though his results



have been mixed — five wins, three losses and two draws — the country is optimistic he can elevate a squad which is seen as less star-studded than Brazil's iconic teams of the

past, despite high-profile players like Neymar and Vinicius Junior.

While Brazil has won the World cup five times — more than any other team — it hasn't lifted the trophy since 2002, an eternity for a soccer-obsessed nation that produced some of the most brilliant players in history, such as Ronaldo, Ronaldinho and Pele.

Since 2002 it has only gotten beyond the quarterfinals once - as World Cup host in 2014 - and even that tournament ended in disappointment after an embarrassing 7-1 semifinal loss to eventual champion Germany.

Criticism justified, I haven't performed well: Gukesh

AJAI MASAND ■ Oslo

Reigning world champion D Gukesh is not ruffled by the barrage of criticism that has come his way in the past 18 months as the young Indian Grandmaster believes all of it is justified given his underwhelming form.

Gukesh, who will turn 20 on May 29, is here to compete in the Norway Chess Tournament and opens his campaign against Germany's Vincent Keymer on Monday. He would be eager to turn things around and log some strong results in the lead-up to his world title defence against challenger Javokhir Sindarov later this year.

"Most of it (critical comments made by former greats) I don't



hear, but there are some that I have heard and I think it's fair," said Gukesh on Sunday.

"I have not been performing well in the last one-and-a-half

year and I think I would say that my performances have been way below expectations. They (critics) have the right to say what they feel and I have the right to do my best," added the reticent teenager while seated alongside one of his critics, former world champion Magnus Carlsen.

The world number one Carlsen is chasing a record-extending eighth Norway Chess title on home soil.

This year, Gukesh finished 10th at the Tata Steel Chess Tournament, followed it up with a ninth-place finish at the Prague International Chess Festival, and most recently finished sixth at the Superbet Rapid & Blitz Poland on the Grand Chess Tour. He pulled

out of all classical events on the Grand Chess Tour and, for now, will play only in Norway Chess and the Chess Olympiad before his World Championship title clash against Sindarov.

Due to his prolonged poor form, Gukesh's world title win in 2024 against China's Ding Liren has been underplayed by the likes of Russian GM Ian Nepomniachtchi, who feels the Indian just "plays badly" at times.

Former world champion Anatoly Karpov has gone to the extent of saying that Gukesh won the coveted crown "by accident". Carlsen has also repeatedly questioned the quality of chess played during the 2024 title clash in Singapore.